

Joanna Newsom Lyrics

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Walnut Whales - 1 - Erin

Erin, Erin, Erin!
Erin across America

Do now cheer me on
Can't you hear the song for you?

Quick, now - caramel dip
Give it up to the runaway ship

Hail, now - hail to the bitch
The hairy literary with the nervous, nervous twitch

Shy, your light pops out
And we stand there astounded
And we pound our heads and shout

We shout halleluja
Look what it did to ya

Oh, a horrible mess
And we're eating by the river in the sunday dress

Oh, serenade me
Eatin' my biscuits and gravy

You are missing from me
As you juggle with your uncle in the red Red Sea

I will wait, or will
Knock my knees and talk to you, oh so still

Oh Shenandoah
We just across the wide Missouri
You are so bonny shhhh do not worry

Quick, now - caramel dip
Give it up to the runaway ship

Life's so sweet and so low
Buried in the water, yeah, buried in the snow

So dear, deep and so dark
Sleeping under papers in the central park

Twentieth floor balcony
Houses what is home to me
Twentieth floor balcony
Houses what is home for me
Twentieth floor balcony
Houses what is home to me

Walnut Whales - 2 - Cassiopeia

Feel the mattress tense beneath me
like the muscle of non-sleepy;
feathers flexing will defeat me,
and it vexes me completely.

And his hexes heat covertly
like a slow low-flying turkey,
like a Texan drying jerky
but his meaty mitts can't hurt me.

With my steely will compounded
in a mighty mound that's hounded
by the snap your steel string sounded
just before your snores unwound it

And in store are dreams so daring
that the night can't stop from staring.
I'll swim sweetly as a herring
through the ether, not despairing.

Go to sleep, you stunning sky;
gently creep cunning by.
A quiet hum is amplified
by your thumb, that you suck dry.

Hundred raging waters
snare the lonely sigh.
Hold your breath
and clasp at Cassiopeia.

Hundred raging waters
snare the lonely sigh.
Hold your breath
and clasp at Cassiopeia.

Cassiopeia, Cassiopeia, Cassiopeia
Cassiopeia, Cassiopeia, Cassiopeia

Walnut Whales - 3 - Peach, Plumb, Pear

We speak in the store
I'm a sensitive bore
and you're markedly more
and I'm oozing surprise.

But it's late in the day
and you're well on your way
and my Valentine's gray
and I'm suddenly shy.

And the gathering floozies
afford to be choosy
and all sneezing darkly
in the dimming divide.

I have read the right books
to interpret your looks
and you're knocking me down
with the palm of your eye.

Nah nah nah nah...

This is unlike the story
it was written to be
I am riding its back
when it used to ride me.

And we are galloping manic
to the mouth of the source
And we are swallowing panic
in the face of its force.

I am blue.
I am blue.
I am blue and unwell,
so I bolt like a horse.

Oh, you're so gone.
To chew some ice.
And you've changed some.

Reduced to tongue eardrum thumb pencil and price.

I'm so dear.

I run rare.

I run rare.

But you've changed some:

peach, plum, pear.

Peach plum!

Walnut Whales - 4 - Clam Crab Cockle Cowrie

That means no where I come from.
I am cold, and waiting for the day to come.

I chew my lips, and I scratch my nose:
feels so good to be a rose.

Oh don't, don't you lift me up
like I'm so shy, no no no no no,
just give it up -
See there are bats all dissolving in a row
into the wishy-washy dark that can't let go.
I cannot let go,
so I thank the lord, and I thank his sword!
'tho it be mincing up the morning,
slightly bored

O, morning without warning like a hole,
And I watch you go.
There are some mornings
when the sky looks like a road.
There are some dragons
who were built to have and hold.
And some machines
are dropped from great heights lovingly.
And some great bellies ache with many bumblebees.

I do as I please.
Now I'm on my knees.
Your skin is something that I stir into my tea.
And I am watching you
and you are starry, starry, starry
and you will never ever know how very sorry
you will be... I am.
Now I'm tumbling down, and I check a frown.
That's why I love this town.
Well, just look around
to see me serenaded hourly!
celebrated sourly! dedicated dourly;
waltzing with the open sea -
clam, crab, cockle, cowrie:

will you just look at me?

Walnut Whales - 5 - Flying a Kite

Dear charming kite
Do lightly bite
The foggy fields, the lowing lanes
The rickety roads and the kneeling plains
Oh lazy light
With massive might

You dare my dream of snowy cloth
Felt snapping white as albatross
Is bitten by the wind and rocks
Is hushed into the clary [?] moss
Is ushered here to count his loss
My kite, pale cotton, willow crossed

You take my tattered fist
It's like a catalyst
It's like a roiling writhing wall of "has it come to this?"

If this is medicine woah-oh
It tastes like medicine
Just help me get it in

Flying a kite
Flying a
Kite flying a kite-
Flying a kite-
Flying a kite-
Flying a kite-
Flying a kite-
Flying
Flying a kite
Oh-woah-oh
[x2]

Oh gnarly night
It's like a dog fight
It's like a cat fight
And if I could just hold you close to me, woah-oh
I guess I'd hold you close to me
It's like a bull fight

And I say I give you a piece of my mind
But I'm giving you a piece of my mouth
You blushing boy how could you be so blind?

Flying a kite
Flying a
Kite flying a kite-
Flying a kite-
Flying a kite-
Flying a kite-
Flying a kite-
Flying
Flying a kite
Oh-woah-oh
[x2]

La da-da, de di
Look at my kite fly
Over foggy fields
The pungent pines
The verdant vales
And the vapid vines
And the thousand purple cups of wine
The tearing teeth and the four full tines
The crumpling feast and the dawdling dying

And you do

Pick me off the floor
Stand there staring for a minute
Like you never saw a girl before
There is the door

At night the streets are like an open mouth
I head south
And you stand fair and square and I stand there
Until the fall blots me out

There is no more
The cat and mouse to block the door
There is no more

Walnut Whales - 6 - The Fray

Bottom of the ninth inning
At which I stray through the crowd
First it was what I call quiet
Then it was biblically loud

You should have seen how they tumbled
You should have seen how they danced
You should have seen them all luscious and lean
As they flew by the seat of their pants

It was not the boilin' frustration
It was not that I cannot care less
It was not the face of that reverent place
In the horrible state of undress

I moved in a way I call mindless
I flatter myself a move true
I carved out a "J" in the spectators' fray
Because that's just the thing that we do

Yes, I carved out my name in the ninth of the game
Because that's just a thing that we do

Walnut Whales - 7 - En Gallop!

This place is damp and ghostly
I am already gone.
And the halls were lined
with the disembodied and the dustly wings,
which fell from flesh gasplessly.

And I go where the trees are,
and I walk from a higher education
(for now, and for hire).

It beats me, but I do not know.
It beats me, but I do not know.
It beats me, but I do not know.
I do not know.

Palaces and stormclouds
the rough, straggly sage, and the smoke
and the way it will all come together
(in quietness, in time).

Bitch, you laws of property
bitch, you free economy
bitch, you unending afterthoughts,
you could've told me before -

Never get so attached to a poem
you forget truth that lacks lyricism;
never draw so close to the heat
that you forget that you must eat.

In order to make the music
seems I must break so many things.
Turn over like bracken and sea-shrapnel
grazed by the tongue of a beetle-green sea.

Let each note be
a full-bodied song:
enough fingers,
enough toes,
skin to cover the rich, bloody beat,

enough belly,
enough feet.

Walnut Whales - 8 - The Book of Right-On

We should shine a light on, a light on.
And the book of right-on's right on,
it was right on.

We should shine a light on, a light on.
And the book of right-on's right on,
it was right on.

I killed my dinner with karate -
kick 'em in the face, taste the body;
shallow work is the work that I do.

Do you want to sit at my table?
My fighting fame is fabled
and fortune finds me fit and able.

And you do say that you do pray,
and you say that you're okay.

Do you want to run with my pack?
Do you want to ride on my back?
Pray that what you lack does not distract.

And even when you run through my mind
something else is in front; you're behind.
And I don't have to remind you
to stick with your kind.

And you do say that you do pray,
and you say that you're okay.

And even when you touch my face
you know your place.

And even when you touch my face
you know your place.

We should shine a light on, a light on.
And the book of right-on's right on,
it was right on.

Yarn And Glue - 1 - Sprout and the Bean

I slept all day
I woke with distaste
and I railed,
and I raved

That the difference between
the sprout and the bean
it is a golden ring,
it is a twisted string.
You can ask the councillor;
and you can ask the king;
and they'll say the same thing;
and it's a funny thing:

Should we go outside?
Should we go outside?
Should we break some bread?
Are y'interested?

And as I said,
I slept as though dead
dreaming seamless dreams of lead.

When you go away,
I am big-boned and fey
in the dust of the day,
and in the dirt of the day.

And the Danger! Danger!
Drawing near them was a broad boat,
and Danger! Danger!
Drawing near them was a white coat,
And the water! water!
Running clear beneath a white throat,
and the hollow chatter
of the talking of the tadpoles,
who know th'outside!
Should we go outside?
Do you know th'outside?
Should we go outside?

Yarn And Glue - 2 - This Side of the Blue

Svetlana sucks lemons across from me,
and I am progressing abominably.
And I do not know my own way to the sea
but the saltiest sea knows its own way to me.

And the city that turns, turns protracted and slow
and I find myself toeing th'Embarcadero
and I find myself knowing
the things that I knew
which is all that you can know
on this side of the blue.

And Jaime has eyes
black and shiny as boots
and they march at you two-by-two
(re-loo re-loo);
when she looks at you,
you know she's nowhere near through:
it's the kindest heart beating
this side of the blue.

And Gabriel stands beneath forest and moon.
See them rattle & boo,
see them shake, see them loom.
See him fashion a cap from a page of Camus;
see him navigate deftly this side of the blue.

And the signifieds butt heads
with the signifiers,
and we all fall down slack-jawed
to marvel at words!
When across the sky sheet the
impossible birds, in a steady,
illiterate movement homewards.

And the rest of our lives
will the moments accrue
when the shape of their goneness
will flare up anew.
Then we do what we have to do

(re-loo re-loo),
which is all that you can do
on this side of the blue.

It's all that you can do
on this side of the blue.

Yarn And Glue - 3 - Yarn and Glue

Do you know what this is son?
This is the panopticon
And all around us blink the brash
And shifty eyes of common cash

So do we die or do we travel?
Down the path by which one dabbles
In the arts of antediluvian crafts
With yarn and glue

So gather twilight to your breast
And couch the rabble-rouser's nest
And we will take a day of rest
And we will all be heaven-blessed

And we will gather 'round to dine
And pass the time with wicked rhymes
And toast in dandelion wines
To hear their mellifluous chimes

We toast the fallow furrows that we sow
We toast the monies that we owe, oh, oh
We toast the creditors we daily face
Who topple down with gruesome grace

And we toast the aristocrats with blood of blue
Because we know our collars are that color, too
And we toast the artisans of antediluvian crafts
With yarn and glue

We do, we do!

Yarn And Glue - 4 - What We Have Known

The tadpole buoyant as basalt
The seahorse horsing in assault
The owlet in his greenery
The narwhal in his cup of sea
They all believe
They all believe

But collusion bleeds through back alleys
From parapets that end on feet
When one is weak they discretely meet
They throw the bones into the street
And they progress
And we retreat

And all the books our fathers wrote
Are in the middle of the road
Little by little, we implode
History brittle, brown and broke
We can't remember what was spoke
So we stare in wonder at the smoke
What it begets is born alone
We know not now what we have known

Ladies, breathe deep against your whalebones
For your children come home made of stone

The terror seething sees a way
Or like the wheezing of the bay
In miniature agonies
They travel westward on the breeze
Bring us all to our knees

The dappled horse, the sorrel mare
With eyes that do not see but stare
Beneath boots as black as malachite
He drives the nag into the night
Into the night

And all the baby boys we've born
With eyes averted from the storm

Sent off to die in perfect form
We know not now what we have known

Satellite photos, rhetoric
See how the euphemisms stick
And when they come back broke and burned
Those who return have no return

Yarn And Glue - 5 - Bridges and Balloons

We sailed away on a winter's day
with fate as malleable as clay;
but ships are fallible, I say,
and the nautical, like all things, fades.

And I can recall our caravel:
a little wicker beetle shell
with four fine masts and lateen sails,
its bearings on Cair Paravel.

O my love,
O it was a funny little thing
to be the ones to've seen.

The sight of bridges and balloons
makes calm canaries irritable;
and they caw and claw all afternoon:
"Catenaries and dirigibles
brace and buoy the living-room -
a loom of metals, warp-woof-wimble."
A thimblesworth of milky moon
can touch hearts larger than a thimble.

O my love,
O it was a funny little thing
to be the ones to've seen.

O my love,
O it was a funny little thing,
it was a funny funny little thing.

The Milk Eyed Mender - 1 - Bridges and Balloons

We sailed away on a winter's day
with fate as malleable as clay;
but ships are fallible, I say,
and the nautical, like all things, fades.

And I can recall our caravel:
a little wicker beetle shell
with four fine masts and lateen sails,
its bearings on Cair Paravel.

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makes calm canaries irritable;
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"Catenaries and dirigibles
brace and buoy the living-room -
a loom of metals, warp-woof-wimble."
And a thimblesworth of milky moon
can touch hearts larger than a thimble.

O my love,
O it was a funny little thing
to be the ones to've seen.

O my love,
O it was a funny little thing,
it was a funny funny little thing.

The Milk Eyed Mender - 2 - Sprout and the Bean

I slept all day
I woke with distaste
and I railed,
and I raved

That the difference between
the sprout and the bean
it is a golden ring,
it is a twisted string.
And you can ask the councillor;
and you can ask the king;
and they'll say the same thing;
and it's a funny thing:

Should we go outside?
Should we go outside?
Should we break some bread?
Are y'interested?

And as I said,
I slept as though dead
dreaming seamless dreams of lead.

When you go away,
I am big-boned and fey
in the dust of the day,
and in the dirt of the day.

And the Danger! Danger!
Drawing near them was a white coat,
and Danger! Danger!
Drawing near them was a broad boat,
And the water! water!
Running clear beneath a white throat,
and the hollow chatter
of the talking of the tadpoles,
who know th'outside!
Should we go outside?
Should we break some bread?
Are y'interested?

The Milk Eyed Mender - 3 - The Book of Right-On

We should shine a light on, a light on.
And the book of right-on's right on,
it was right on.

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I killed my dinner with karate -
kick 'em in the face, taste the body;
shallow work is the work that I do.

Do you want to sit at my table?
My fighting fame is fabled
and fortune finds me fit and able.

And you do say that you do pray,
and you say that you're okay.

And do you want to run with my pack?
Do you want to ride on my back?
Pray that what you lack does not distract.

And even when you run through my mind
something else is in front; you're behind.
And I don't have to remind you
to stick with your kind.

And you do say that you do pray,
and you say that you're okay.

And even when you touch my face
you know your place.

And even when you touch my face
you know your place.

We should shine a light on, a light on.
And the book of right-on's right on,
it was right on.

The Milk Eyed Mender - 4 - Sadie

Sadie, white coat,
you carry me home.
And bury this bone,
and take this pine-cone.

Bury this bone to gnaw on it later;
gnawing on the telephone, and
'Till then, we pray & suspend
the notion that these lives do never end.

And all day long we talk about mercy:
lead me to water lord, I sure am thirsty
Down in the ditch where I nearly served you
up in the clouds where he almost heard you

And all that we built
and all that we breathed,
and all that we spilt, or pulled up like weeds
is piled up in back;
and it burns irrevocably.
(and we spoke up in turns,
'till the silence crept over me)

And bless you and I deeply do
no longer resolute, and I call to you

But the water got so cold,
and you do lose
what you don't hold.

This is an old song, these are old blues.
This is not my tune, but it's mine to use.
And the seabirds where the fear once grew
will flock with a fury,
and they will bury what'd come for you.

And down where I darn with the milk-eyed mender
you and I, and a love so tender,
stretched-on a hoop where I stitch-this adage:
"Bless our house and its heart so savage."

And all that I want, and all that I need,
and all that I got is scattered like seed.
And all that I knew is moving away from me.
(and all that I know is blowing
like tumbleweed)

And the mealy worms
in the brine will burn
in the salty pyre,
among the fauns and ferns.

And the love we hold,
and the love we spurn,
will never grow cold
only taciturn.

And I'll tell you tomorrow.
Sadie, go on home now.
And bless those who sicken below;
and bless us who have chosen so.

And all that I got
and all that I need
I tie in a knot
and I lay at your feet.
And I have not forgot,
but a silence crept over me.
(So dig up your bone,
exhume your pine-cone, my Sadie)

The Milk Eyed Mender - 5 - Inflammatory Writ

Oh, where is your inflammatory writ?
Your text that would incite a light, "Be lit"?
Our music deserving devotion unswerving -
Cry "Do I deserve her?" with unflagging fervor.
(Well, no we do not, if we cannot get over it)

But what's it mean
when suddenly we're spent?
Tell me true!
Ambition came and reared its head, and went
far from you!
Even mollusks have weddings,
though solemn and leaden
but you dirge for the dead,
and take no jam on your bread -
just a supper of salt and a waltz
through your empty bed.

And all at once it came to me,
and I wrote him hunched 'till four-thirty
But that vestal light,
it burns out with the night
in spite of all the time that we spend on it:
on one bedraggled ghost of a sonnet!
While outside, the wild boars root
without bending a bough underfoot -
O it breaks my heart; I don't know how they do't.
So don't ask me!

And as for my inflammatory writ?
Well, I wrote it and I was not inflamed one bit.
Advice from the master derailed that disaster;
He said "Hand that pen over to me, poetaster!"
While across the great plains,
keening lovely & awful,
ululate the lost Great American Novels -
An unlawful lot, left to stutter and freeze, floodlit.
(But at least they didn't run,
to their undying credit.)

The Milk Eyed Mender - 6 - This Side of the Blue

Svetlana sucks lemons across from me,
and I am progressing abominably.
And I do not know my own way to the sea
but the saltiest sea knows its own way to me.

And the city that turns, turns protracted and slow
and I find myself toeing th'Embarcadero
and I find myself knowing
the things that I knew
which is all that you can know
on this side of the blue.

And Jaime has eyes
black and shiny as boots
and they march at you two-by-two
(re-loo re-loo);
when she looks at you,
you know she's nowhere near through:
it's the kindest heart beating
this side of the blue.

And the signifieds butt heads
with the signifiers,
and we all fall down slack-jawed
to marvel at words!
When across the sky sheet the
impossible birds, in a steady,
illiterate movement homewards.

And Gabriel stands beneath forest and moon.
See them rattle & boo,
see them shake, and see them loom.
See him fashion a cap from a page of Camus;
and see him navigate deftly this side of the blue.

And the rest of our lives
will the moments accrue
when the shape of their goneness
will flare up anew.
Then we do what we have to do

(re-loo re-loo),
which is all that you can do
on this side of the blue.

It's all that you can do
on this side of the blue.

The Milk Eyed Mender - 7 - "En Gallop"

This place is damp and ghostly
I am already gone.
And the halls were lined
with the disembodied and the dustly wings,
which fell from flesh gasplessly.

And I go where the trees go,
and I walk from a higher education
(for now, and for hire).

It beats me, but I do not know.
And it beats me, but I do not know.
It beats me, but I do not know.
I do not know.

Palaces and stormclouds
and the rough, straggly sage, and the smoke
and the way it will all come together
(in quietness, and in time).

And you laws of property
you free economy
and you unending afterthoughts,
you could've told me before -

Never get so attached to a poem
you forget truth that lacks lyricism;
and never draw so close to the heat
that you forget that you must eat.

The Milk Eyed Mender - 8 - Cassiopeia

Feel the mattress tense beneath me
like the muscle of non-sleepy;
feathers flexing will defeat me,
and it vexes me completely.

And the hexes heat covertly
like a slow low-flying turkey,
like a Texan drying jerky
but his meaty mitts can't hurt me.

With my steely will compounded
in a mighty mound that's hounded
by the snap your steel string sounded
just before your snores unwound it

And in store are dreams so daring
that the night can't stop from staring.
And I'll swim sweetly as a herring
through the ether, not despairing.

Go to sleep, you stunning sky;
gently creep cunning by.
A quiet hum is amplified
by your thumb, that you suck dry.

Hundred raging waters
snare the lonely sigh.
And you hold your breath
and clasp at Cassiopeia.

Hundred raging waters
snare the lonely sigh.
And you hold your breath
and clasp at Cassiopeia.

Cassiopeia, Cassiopeia, Cassiopeia

The Milk Eyed Mender - 9 - Peach, Plum, Pear

We speak in the store
I'm a sensitive bore
you seem markedly more
and I'm oozing surprise.

But it's late in the day
and you're well on your way
what was golden went gray
and I'm suddenly shy.

And the gathering floozies
afford to be choosy
and all sneezing darkly
in the dimming divide.

And I have read the right books
to interpret your looks
you were knocking me down
with the palm of your eye.

Nah nah nah nah...

This is unlike the story
it was written to be
I was riding its back
when it used to ride me.

And we were galloping manic
to the mouth of the source
we were swallowing panic
in the face of its force.

And I was blue.
I am blue and unwell,
made me bolt like a horse

Nah nah nah nah...

Now it's done.
Watch it go.

And you've changed some.
Water running from the snow.

Am I so dear?
Do I run rare?
And you've changed some:
peach, plum, pear.

Peach plum!

The Milk Eyed Mender - 10 - Swansea

If you want to come on down,
down with your bones so white,
watch while the freight trains pound
into the wild, wild night

How I would love to gnaw,
to gnaw on your bones so white,
and watch while the freight trains paw,
paw at the wild, wild night.

All these ghost towns, wreathed in old loam
(Assateague knee-deep in seafoam) -
Ho Swansea! Buttonwillow!
Lagunitas! Ho Calico!

And all these beastly bungalows
stare, distend, like endless toads -
endlessly hop down the road.
Borne by wind, we southward blow.

And yonder, wild and blue,
the wild blue yonder looms.
'Till we are wracked with rheum,
by roads, by songs entombed.

And all we want to do
is chew, and chew, and chew!
Dear one, drive on,
when all we want to do
is chew, and chew, and chew.

And if you want to come on down
down with your bones so white.
Watch while the freight trains pound
into the wild, wild night.

How I would love to gnaw,
to gnaw on your bones so white,
and watch while the freight trains paw,
paw at the wild, wild night,

paw at the wild, wild night,
paw at the wild, wild night.

The Milk Eyed Mender - 11 - Three Little Babes

There was a knight, and a lady bright
and three little babes had she.
She sent them away, to a far country,
to learn their grammerie.

They hadn't been gone but a very short time,
about three months and a day,
when the lark spread o'er this whole wide world
and taken those babes away.

It was on a cold, cold Christmas night,
when everything was still,
and she saw her three little babes come running
come running down the hill.

She set them a table of bread and wine,
that they might drink and eat;
she spread them a bed of winding sheet,
that they might sleep so sweet.

"Take it off, take it off," cried the eldest one;
"Take it off, take it off," cried she,
"For I shan't stay here, in this wicked world,
when there's a better one for me."

"Cold clods, cold clods, inside my bed,
cold clods, down at my feet -
The tears my dear mother shed for me
would wet my winding sheet."

"The tears my dear mother shed for me
would wet my winding sheet
would wet my winding sheet."

The Milk Eyed Mender - 12 - Clam, Crab, Cockle, Cowrie

That means no where I come from.
I am cold, out waiting for the day to come.

I chew my lips, and I scratch my nose:
feels so good to be a rose.

Oh don't, don't you lift me up
like I'm that shy, no no no no no,
just give it up -
There are bats all dissolving in a row
into the wishy-washy dark that cannot let go.
And I cannot let go,
and so I thank the lord, and I thank his sword!
'tho it be mincing up the morning,
slightly bored

O, morning without warning like a hole,
And I watch you go.
There are some mornings
when the sky looks like a road.
There are some dragons
who were built to have and hold.
And some machines
are dropped from great heights lovingly.
And some great bellies ache with many bumblebees
(and they sting so terribly).

I do as I please.
Now I'm on my knees.
Your skin is something that I stir into my tea.
And I am watching you
and you are starry, starry, starry
and I'm tumbling down, and I check a frown.
That's why I love this town.
Well, just look around
to see me serenaded hourly!
and celebrated sourly! and dedicated dourly;
waltzing with the open sea -
clam, crab, cockle, cowrie:
will you just look at me?

Sprout And The Bean Single - 1 - Sprout and the Bean

I slept all day
I woke with distaste
and I railed,
and I raved

That the difference between
the sprout and the bean
it is a golden ring,
it is a twisted string.
And you can ask the councillor;
and you can ask the king;
and they'll say the same thing;
and it's a funny thing:

Should we go outside?
Should we go outside?
Should we break some bread?
Are y'interested?

And as I said,
I slept as though dead
dreaming seamless dreams of lead.

When you go away,
I am big-boned and fey
in the dust of the day,
and in the dirt of the day.

And the Danger! Danger!
Drawing near them was a white coat,
and Danger! Danger!
Drawing near them was a broad boat,
And the water! water!
Running clear beneath a white throat,
and the hollow chatter
of the talking of the tadpoles,
who know th'outside!
Should we go outside?
Should we break some bread?
Are y'interested?

Sprout And The Bean Single - 2 - What We Have Known

The tadpole buoyant as basalt
The seahorse horsing in assault
The owlet in his greenery
The narwhal in his cup of sea
They all believe
They all believe

But collusion bleeds through back alleys
From parapets that end in feet
When one is weak we discretely meet
We throw the bones into the street
As they progress
We retreat

And all the books our fathers wrote
Are in the middle of the road
Little by little, we implode
History brittle, brown and broke
We can't remember what was spoke
So we stare in wonder at the smoke
What it begets is born alone
We know not now what we have known

Ladies, breathe deep against your whalebones
When your children come back made of stone

And the terror seething sees a way
It is like the wheezing of the bay
In miniature agonies
They travel westward on the breeze
And bring us all to our knees

And the dappled horse, the sorrel mare
With eyes that do not see but stare
Beneath boots as black as malachite
He drives the nag into the night
Into the night

And all the baby boys we've born
With eyes averted from the storm

Sent off to die in perfect form
We know not now what we have known

Satellite photos and rhetoric
See how the euphemisms stick
And when they come back broke and burned
Those who return have no return

Ladies, breathe deep against your whalebones
When your children come back made of stone

Ys - 1 - Emily

The meadowlark and the chim-choo-ree and the sparrow
set to the sky in a flying spree, for the sport of the pharaoh.
Little while later, the Pharisees dragged a comb through the meadow.
Do you remember what they called up to you and me, in our window?

There is a rusty light on the pines tonight;
sun pouring wine, lord, or marrow, into the
bones of the birches, and the spires of the churches, jutting out from the shadows;
the yoke, and the axe, and the old smokestacks, and the bale, and the barrow -
and everything sloped, like it was dragged from a rope, in the mouth of the south below.

We've seen those mountains kneeling, felten and grey.
We thought our very hearts would up and melt away,

from that snow in the nighttime,
just going and going

and the stirring of wind chimes
in the morning
in the morning

Helps me find my way back in
from the place where I have been -

And, Emily, I saw you last night by the river.
I dreamed you were skipping little stones across the surface of the water -
frowning at the angle where they were lost, and slipped under forever,
in a mud-cloud, mica-spangled, like the sky'd been breathing on a mirror.

Anyhow, I sat by your side, by the water.
You taught me the names of the stars overhead, that I wrote down in my ledger -
though all I knew of the rote universe were those Pleiades, loosed in December,
I promised you I'd set them to verse, so I'd always remember

That the meteorite is the source of the light,
And the meteor's just what we see;
And the meteoroid is a stone that's devoid of the fire that propelled it to thee.
And the meteorite's just what causes the light,
And the meteor's how it's perceived;
And the meteoroid's a bone thrown from the void, that lies quiet in offering to thee.

*

You came and lay a cold compress upon the mess I'm in;
threw the windows wide, and cried amen amen amen.
The whole world stopped to hear you hollering.
And you looked down, and saw, now, what was happening:

The lines are fading in my kingdom
(though I have never known the way to border them in);
so the muddy mouths of baboons and sows, and the grouse, and the horse, and the hen
grope at the gate of the looming lake that was once a tidy pen.
And the mail is late, and the great estates are not lit from within.
The talk in town's becoming downright sickening.

In due time we will see the far buttes lit by a flare.
I've seen your bravery, and I will follow you there

And row through the nighttime,
so healthy,
gone healthy all of a sudden,

In search of a midwife
who can help me
who can help me,

help me find my way back in.
And there are worries where I've been.

And say, say, say, in the lee of the bay
don't be bothered.
Leave your troubles here,
where the tugboats shear the water from the water
(flanked by furrows, curling back, like a match held up to a newspaper).

Emily, they'll follow your lead by the letter.
And I make this claim, and I'm not ashamed to say I knew you better.
What they've seen is just a beam of your sun that banishes winter.

Let us go! Though we know it's a hopeless endeavor.
The ties that bind, they are barbed and spined, and hold us close forever.

Though there is nothing would help me come to grips with

a sky that is gaping and yawning,
there is a song I woke with on my lips,
as you sailed your great ship towards the morning.

*

Come on home. The poppies are all grown knee-deep by now.
Blossoms all have fallen, and the pollen ruins the plow.
Peonies nod in the breeze,
and while they wetly bow
with hydrocephalitic listlessness,
ants mop up their brow.

And everything with wings is restless, aimless, drunk and dour;
butterflies and birds collide at hot, ungodly hours.
And my clay-colored motherlessness rangily reclines -
Come on home, now! All my bones are dolorous with vines.

Pa pointed out to me, for the hundredth time tonight,
the way the ladle leads to a dirt-red bullet of light.

Squint skyward and listen -
loving him, we move within his borders:
just asterisms in the stars' set order.

We could stand for a century,
staring,
with our heads cocked,
in the broad daylight, at this thing:

Joy,
landlocked in bodies that don't keep -
dumbstruck with the sweetness of being,
till we don't be.
Told: take this.
And eat this.

Told: the meteorite is the source of the light,
And the meteor's just what we see;
And the meteoroid is a stone that's devoid of the fire that propelled it to thee.

And the meteorite is just what causes the light,
And the meteor's how it's perceived;

And the meteoroid's a bone thrown from the void that lies quiet in offering to thee.

Ys - 2 - Monkey & Bear

Down in the green hay,
where monkey and bear usually lay,
they woke from a stable-boy's cry.
He said: "someone come quick -
the horses got loose, got grass-sick -
they'll founder! Fain, they'll die."

What is now known by the sorrel and the roan?
By the chestnut, and the bay, and the gelding grey?
It is: stay by the gate that you are given.
And remain in your place, for your season.
And had the overfed dead but listened
to the high-fence, horse-sense, wisdom...

"Did you hear that, bear?" said
monkey, "we'll get out of here, fair and square
they left the gate open wide!

"So, my bride.

"Here is my hand. Where is your paw?
Try and understand my plan, Ursala.
My heart is a furnace
full of love that's just, and earnest.
Now.
You know that we must unlearn this
allegiance to a life of service,
and no longer answer to that heartless
hay-monger, nor be his accomplice -
(the charlatan, with artless hustling!)
But Ursala, we've got to eat something,
and earn our keep, while still within
the borders of the land that man has girded,
(all double-bolted and tightfisted!),
until we reach the open country,
a-steeped in milk and honey.
Will you keep your fancy clothes on, for me?
Can you bear a little longer to wear that leash?

"My love, I swear by the air I breathe:

Sooner or later, you'll bare your teeth.

"But for now, just dance, darling.
C'mon, will you dance, my darling?
Darling, there's a place for us;
can we go, before I turn to dust?
My darling there's a place for us.

"Darling. C'mon will you dance,
My darling?
The hills are groaning with excess,
like a table ceaselessly being set.
My darling we will get there yet."

They trooped past the guards,
past the coops, and the fields, and the
farmyards, all night, till finally,

the space they gained
grew much farther than
the stone that bear threw,
to mark where they'd stop for tea.

But,
"Walk a little faster,
don't look backwards -

"your feast is to the East, which lies a little past the pasture.

"When the blackbirds hear tea whistling they rise and clap.
Their applause caws the kettle black.
And we can't have none of that!
Move along, Bear; there, there; that's that."

(Though cast in plaster,
our Ursala's heart beat faster
than monkey's ever will.)

But still,
they have got to pay the bills.
Hadn't they?
That is what the monkey'd say.
So, with the courage of a clown, or a cur,

or a kite, jerking tight at its tether,
in her dun-brown gown of fur,
and her jerkin of
swansdown and leather,
Bear would sway on her hind legs;
the organ would grind dregs of song,
for the pleasure
of the children who'd shriek,
throwing coins at her feet,
then recoiling in terror.

Sing, "dance, darling.
C'mon, will you dance, my darling?
Darling, there's a place for us;
can we go, before I turn to dust?
My darling there's a place for us.

"Darling.
C'mon, will you dance, my darling?
You keep your eyes fixed on the highest hill,
where you'll ever-after eat your fill.
O my darling...dear...mine...if you dance,
dance darling and I'll love you still."

*

Deep in the night
shone a weak and miserly light,
where the monkey shouldered his lamp.
Someone had told him the
bear'd been wandering a fair piece away
from where they were camped.
Someone had told him
the bear had been sneaking away,
to the seaside caverns, to bathe;
and the thought troubled the monkey,
for he was afraid of spelunking
down in those caves.
Also afraid what the
village people would say,
if they saw the bear in that state -
lolling and splashing obscenely
well, it seemed irrational, really,

washing that face;
washing that matted and flea-bit pelt
in some sea-spit-shine -
old kelp dripping with brine.
But monkey just laughed, and he muttered,
"When she comes back, Ursala will be bursting with pride -
till I jump up!
Saying, 'You've been rolling in muck!
Saying, 'You smell of garbage and grime!'"

But far out,
far out,
by now,
by now -
far out, by now, Bear ploughed,
Because she would
Not drown:

First the outside-legs of the bear
up and fell down, in the water, like knobby garters,
Then the outside-arms of the bear
fell off, as easy as if sloughed
from boiled tomatoes.
Low'red in a genteel curtsy,
bear shed the mantle of her
diluvian shoulders;
and, with a sigh,
she allowed the burden of belly to drop,
like an apronfull of boulders.

If you could hold up her
threadbare coat to the light,
where it's worn translucent in places,
you'd see spots where,
almost every night of the year,
Bear had been mending,
suspending that baseness.

Now her coat drags through the water,
bagging, with a life's-worth of hunger,
limitless minnows;

in the magnetic embrace,

balletic and glacial,
of bear's insatiable shadow -

Left there!
Left there!
When bear
Left bear;

Left there,
Left there,
When bear
stepped clear of bear.

(Sooner or later you'll bury your teeth)

Ys - 3 - Sawdust & Diamonds

From the top of the flight
of the wide, white stairs,
through the rest of my life,
do you wait for me there?

There's a bell in my ears.
There's the wide, white roar.
Drop a bell down the stairs.
Hear it fall forevermore.
Hear it fall forevermore.

Drop a bell off of the dock.
Blot it out in the sea.
Drowning mute as a rock;
and sounding mutiny.

There's a light in the wings, hits the system of strings,
from the side, where they swing -
see the wires, the wires, the wires.
And the articulation in our elbows and knees
makes us buckle;
and we couple in endless increase
as the audience admires.

And the little white dove,
made with love, made with love;
made with glue, and a glove, and some pliers

swings a low sickle arc, from its perch in the dark:
settle down, settle down, my desire.

And the moment I slept, I was swept up in a terrible tremor.
Though no longer bereft, how I shook! And I couldn't remember.
And then the furthestmost shake drove a murdering stake in,
and cleft me right down through my center.
And I shouldn't say so, but I know that it was then, or never.

Push me back into a tree.
Bind my buttons with salt.
Fill my long ears with bees

praying please please please love
you ought not
No you ought not

And then the system of strings tugs on the tip of my wings
(cut from cardboard and old magazines):
makes me warble and rise, like a sparrow.
And in the place where I stood, there is a circle of wood -
a cord or two - which you chop, and you stack in your barrow.
It is terribly good to carry water and chop wood,
streaked with soot, heavy-booted and wild-eyed;
as I crash through the rafters,
and the ropes and the pulleys trail after
and the holiest belfry burns sky-high.

And then the slow lip of fire moves across the prairie with precision,
while, somewhere, with your pliers and glue, you make your first incision.
And in a moment of almost-unbearable vision,
doubled over with the hunger of lions,
Hold me close, cooed the dove,
who was stuffed, now, with sawdust and diamonds.

I wanted to say: Why the long face.
Sparrow, perch and play songs of long face.
Burro, buck and bray songs of long face!
Sing, I will swallow your sadness, and eat your cold clay,
just to lift your long face;
And though it may be madness, I will take to the grave
your precious longface.
And though our bones they may break, and our souls separate -
Why the long face?
And though our bodies recoil from the grip of the soil -
Why the long face?

And in the trough of the waves,
which are pawing like dogs,
pitch we, pale-faced and grave,
as I write in my log.

Then I hear a noise from the hull,
seven days out to sea.
And it is the damnable bell!
And it tolls - well, I believe that it tolls - it tolls for me.

And it tolls for me.

And though my wrists and my waist seemed so easy to break,
still, my dear, I'd have walked you to the edge of the water.
And they will recognize all the lines of your face
in the face of the daughter of the daughter of my daughter.

And darling, we will be fine; but what was yours and mine
appears to me a sandcastle
that the gibbering wave takes.
But if it's all just the same, then will you say my name;
say my name in the morning, so that I know when the wave breaks.

I wasn't born of a whistle, or milked from a thistle at twilight.
No; I was all horns and thorns, sprung out fully formed, knock-kneed and upright.

So: enough of this terror.
We deserve to know light,
and grow evermore lighter and lighter.
You would have seen me through,
But I could not undo that desire.

O, desire!
O, desire!
O, desire!
Desire, desire, desire, desire.

From the top of the flight
of the wide, white stairs
Through the rest of my life
Do you wait for me there?

Ys - 4 - Only Skin

And there was a booming above you,
that night black airplanes flew over the sea.
And they were lowing and shifting like
beached whales,
shelled snails,
as you strained and you squinted to see
the retreat of their hairless and blind cavalry.

You froze in your sand shoal,
prayed for your poor soul;
sky was a bread roll, soaking in a milk-bowl.

And when the bread broke -
fell in bricks of wet smoke -
my sleeping heart woke, and my waking heart spoke.

Then there was a silence you took to mean something:
Run, sing,
for alive you will evermore be.
And the plague of the greasy black engines a-skulking
has gone east,
while you're left to explain them to me -
released
from their hairless and blind cavalry.

With your hands in your pockets,
stubbily running
to where I'm unfresh,
undressed and yawning -

Well, what is this craziness?
This crazy talking?
You caught some small death
when you were sleepwalking.

It was a dark dream, darlin;
it's over.
The firebreather is beneath the clover.
Beneath his breathing there is cold clay, forever:
a toothless hound-dog choking on a feather.

But I took my fishing pole (fearing your fever),
down to the swimming hole, where there grows a bitter herb
that blooms but one day a year, by the riverside -
I'd bring it here:

Apply it gently
to the love you've lent me.

While the river was twisting and braiding, the bait bobbed
and the string sobbed,
as it cut through the hustling breeze.

And I watched how the water was kneading so neatly,
gone treacly,
nearly slowed to a stop in this heat;
in a frenzy coiling flush along the muscles beneath.

Press on me,
we are restless things.
Webs of seaweed are swaddling.
And you call upon the dusk of the
musk of a squid:
shot full of ink, until you sink into your crib.

Rowing along, among the reeds, among the rushes,
I heard your song, before my heart had time to hush it!
Smell of a stonefruit being cut and being opened.
Smell of a low and of a lazy cinder smoking

And when the fire moves away,
fire moves away, son.
Why would you say
I was the last one?

Scrape your knee: it is only skin.
Makes the sound of violins.

And when I cut your hair, and leave the birds all of the trimmings,
I am the happiest woman among all women.

And the shallow water stretches as far as I can see.
Knee deep, trudging along -

the seagull weeps 'so long' -
humming a threshing song -

Until the night is over, hold on,
hold on;
hold your horses back from the fickle dawn.

I have got some business out at the edge of town,
candy weighing both of my pockets down
till I can hardly stay afloat, from the weight of them
(and knowing how the commonfolk condemn
what it is I do, to you, to keep you warm:
Being a woman. Being a woman.)

But always up the mountainside you're clambering,
groping blindly, hungry for anything;
picking through your pocket linings -
well, what is this?
Scrap of sassafras, eh Sisyphus?

I see the blossoms broke and wet after the rain.
Little sister, he will be back again.
I have washed a thousand spiders down the drain.
Spiders' ghosts hang, soaked and
dangling silently, from all the blooming cherry trees,
in tiny nooses, safe from everyone -
nothing but a nuisance; gone now, dead and done -
Be a woman. Be a woman.

Though we felt the spray of the waves,
we decided to stay, 'till the tide rose too far.
We weren't afraid, cause we know what you are;
and you know that we know what you are.

Awful atoll -
O, incalculable indiscreetness and sorrow!
Bawl bellow:
Sibyl sea-cow, all done up in a bow.
Toddle and roll;
teethe an impalpable bit of leather,
while yarrow, heather and hollyhock
awkwardly molt along the shore.

Are you mine?
My heart?
Mine anymore?

Stay with me for awhile.
That's an awfully real gun.
I know life will lay you down,
as the lightning has lately done.

Failing this, failing this,
follow me, my sweetest friend,
to see what you anointed,
in pointing your gun there.
Lay it down! Nice and slow!
There is nowhere to go,

save up;
up where the light, undiluted, is
weaving, in a drunk dream,
at the sight of my baby, out back:

back on the patio,
watching the bats bring night in

- while, elsewhere,
estuaries of wax-white
wend, endlessly, towards seashores unmapped.

*

Last week, our picture window
produced a half-word,
heavy and hollow,
hit by a brown bird.

We stood and watched her gape like a rattlesnake
and pant and labor over every intake.

I said a sort of prayer for some rare grace,
then thought I ought to take her to a higher place.
Said, "dog nor vulture nor cat shall toy with you,
and though you die, bird, you will have a fine view."

Then in my hot hand, she slumped her sick weight.
We tramped through the poison oak, heartbroke and inchoate.
The dogs were snapping, and you cuffed their collars
while I climbed the tree-house. Then how I hollered!

Well she'd lain, as still as a stone, in my palm, for a lifetime or two;
then saw the treetops, cocked her head, and up and flew.
(While back in the world that moves, often, according to
the hoarding of these clues,
dogs still run roughly around
little tufts of finch-down.)

And the cities we passed were a flickering wasteland,
but his hand, in my hand, made them hale and harmless.

While down in the lowlands, the crops are all coming;
we have everything.

Life is thundering blissful towards death

in a stampede
of his fumbling green gentleness.

You stopped by;
I was all alive.
In my doorway, we shucked and jived.
And when you wept, I was gone;
see, I got gone when I got wise.
But I can't with certainty say we survived.

Then down and down
and down and down
and down and deeper,
stoke, without sound,
the blameless flames,
you endless sleeper.

Through fire below,
and fire above,
and fire within,

sleep through the things that couldn't have been,
if you hadn't have been.

And when the fire moves away,
fire moves away, son.
And why would you say
I was the last one?

All my bones, they are gone, gone, gone.
Take my bones, I don't need none.
Cold, cold cupboard, lord, nothing to chew on!
Suck all day on a cherry stone.
Dig a little hole not three inches round -
Spit your pit in a hole in the ground.
Weep upon the spot for the starving of me!
Till up grows a fine young cherry tree.
When the bough breaks, what'll you make for me?
A little willow cabin to rest on your knee.
Well, what will I do with a trinket such as this?
Think of your woman, who's gone to the west.
But I'm starving and freezing in my measly old bed!
Then I'll crawl across the salt flats, to stroke your sweet head.
Come across the desert with no shoes on!
I love you truly,
or I love no-one.

Fire moves away. Fire moves away, son.
Why would you say that I was the last one?
Last one?

Clear the room! There's a fire, a fire, a fire.
Get going,
and I'm going to be right behind you.

And if the love of a woman or two, dear,
could move you to such heights,
then all I can do
is do, my darling, right by you.

Ys - 5 - Cosmia

When you ate,
I saw your eyelashes.
Saw them shake like
wind on rushes.

In the cornfield,
when she called me

Moths surround me.
Thought they'd drown me.

And I miss your precious heart.
And I miss your precious heart.

Dried rose petals -
redbrown circles -
frame your eyes and
stain your knuckles.

Dried rose petals -
redbrown circles -
frame your eyes and
stain your knuckles.

And all those lonely nights
down by the river,
brought me bread and water
(Water, in.);

But though I tried so hard,
my little darlin,
I couldn't keep the night from coming in.

And all those lonely nights
down by the river,
brought me bread and water
by the kith and the kin;

Now in the quiet hour,
when I am sleeping,

I cannot keep the night from coming in.

Why've you gone away?

Gone away again?

I'll sleep through the rest of my days,
if you've gone away again.

I'll sleep through the rest of my days.

And I will sleep through the rest of my days.

And I'll sleep through the rest of my days.

Why've you gone away.

Seven suns, seven suns away, away.

Away, away.

Can you hear me? Will you listen?

Don't come near me. Don't go missing.

And in the lissome light of evening:

Help me, Cosmia; I'm grieving.

And all those lonely nights

down by the river,

Brought me bread and water

(Water, in.);

But though I tried so hard,

my little darlin,

I couldn't keep the night from coming in.

And all those lonely nights

down by the river

brought me bread and water

in the kith and the kin;

Now in the quiet hour,

when I am sleeping,

I cannot keep the night from coming in.

*

Beneath the porch-light

we've all been circling.

Beat our dust hearts;

singe our flour wings.

But in the corner,
something is happening!
Wild Cosmia, what have you seen?

Water were your limbs,
and the fire was your hair -
and then the moonlight caught your eye,
and you rose through the air
well, if you've seen true light,
then this is my prayer:

will you call me, when you get there?

And I miss your precious heart;
And I miss your precious heart;
and miss, and miss, and miss,
& miss, & miss, &
miss, & miss, & miss your heart.

But release your precious heart,
to its feast, for precious hearts.

Joanna Newsom And The Ys Street Band - 1 - Colleen

I tell it as I best know how,
And that's the way it was told to me:
Must have once been a thief or a whore,
Then surely was thrown overboard,
Where, they say,
I came their way from the deep blue sea.

It picked me up and tossed me round.
I lost my shoes and tore my gown.
Forgot my name,
And drowned.

Then woke up with the surf a-pounding;
It seemed I had been run aground.

Well they took me in and shod my feet
And taught me prayers for chastity
And said my name would be Colleen, and
I was blessed among all women,
To have forgotten everything.

And as the weeks and months ensued
I tried to make myself of use.
Tilled and planted, but could not produce -
not root, nor leaf, nor flower, nor bean; Lord!
It seemed I overwatered everything.

And I hate the sight of that empty air,
like stepping for a missing stair
and falling forth forever blindly:
cannot grab hold of anything! No,
Not I, most blessed among Colleens.

*

I dream some nights of a funny sea,
as soft as a newly born baby.

It cries for me so pitifully!
And I dive for my child with a wildness in me,

and am so sweetly there received.

But last night came a different dream;
a gray and sloping-shouldered thing
said "What's cinched 'round your waist, Colleen?
Is that my very own baleen?
No! Have you forgotten everything?"

This morning, 'round the cape at dawn,
some travellers sailed into town
with scraps for sale and the saddest songs
and a book of pictures, leather-bound, that
showed a whale with a tusk a meter long.

Well I asked the man who showed it me,
"What is the name of that strange beast?"
He said its name translated roughly to
He-Who-Easily-Can-Curve-Himself-Against-The-Sky.

And I am without words.
He said, "My lady looks perturbed.
(the light is in your eyes, Colleen)."
I said, "Whatever can you mean?"
He leaned in and said,
"You ain't forgotten everything."

*

"You dare to speak a lady's name?"
He says, "My lady is mistaken.
I would not speak your name in this place;
and if I were to try then the wind - I swear -
would rise, to tear you clean from me without a
trace."

"Have you come, then, to rescue me?"
He laughed and said, "from what, 'colleen'?"
You dried and dressed most willingly.
you corseted, and caught the dread disease
by which one comes to know such peace."

Well, it's true that I came to know such things as
the laws that govern property

and the herbs to feed the babes that wean,
and the welting weight for every season;
but still
I don't know any goddamned "Colleen."

*

Then dive down there with the lights to lead
that seem to shine from everything -
down to the bottom of the deep blue sea;
down where your heart beats so slow,
and you never in your life have felt so free.
Will you come down there with me?
Down where our bodies start to seem like
artifacts of some strange dream,
which afterwards you can't decipher,
and so, soon, have forgotten
Everything.

*

Joanna Newsom And The Ys Street Band - 2 - Clam, Crab, Cockle, Cowrie

That means no where I come from.
I am cold, out waiting for the day to come.

I chew my lips, and I scratch my nose:
feels so good to be a rose.

Oh don't, don't you lift me up
like I'm that shy, no no no no no,
just give it up -
There are bats all dissolving in a row
into the wishy-washy dark that cannot let go.
Well I cannot let go,
so I thank the lord, and I thank his sword!
'tho it be mincing up the morning,
slightly bored

O, morning without warning like a hole,
And I watch you go.
There are some mornings
when the sky looks like a road.
And there are some dragons
who were built to have and hold.
And some machines
are dropped from great heights lovingly.
And some great bellies ache with many bumblebees
(and they sting so terribly).

I do as I please.
And now I'm on my knees.
Your skin is something that I stir into my tea.
(Second voice: Your soul is something that I stir into my tea)
And I am watching you
and you are starry, starry, starry
and I'm tumbling down, and I check a frown.
Well, just look around.
It's why I love this town:
just see me serenaded hourly!
and celebrated sourly! and dedicated dourly;
waltzing with the open sea -

clam, crab, cockle, cowrie:
will you just look at me?

Joanna Newsom And The Ys Street Band - 3 - Cosmia

When you ate,
I saw your eyelashes.
Saw them shake like
wind on rushes.

In the cornfield,
when she called me

Moths surround me.
Thought they'd drown me.

And I miss your precious heart.
And I miss your precious heart.

Dried rose petals -
redbrown circles -
framed your eyes and
stained your knuckles.

Dried rose petals -
redbrown circles -
framed your eyes and
stained your knuckles.

And all those lonely nights
down by the river,
brought you bread and water
(Water, in.);

But though I tried so hard,
my little darlin,
I couldn't keep the night from coming in.

And all those lonely nights
down by the river,
brought me bread and water
by the kith and the kin;

Now in the quiet hour,
when I am sleeping,

I cannot keep the night from coming in.

Why've you gone away?

Gone away again?

I'll sleep through the rest of my days,
if you've gone away again.

I'll sleep through the rest of my days.

I'll sleep through the rest of my days.

And I will sleep through the rest of my days.

Why've you gone away, away.

Seven suns, seven suns away, away.

Away, away.

Can you hear me? Will you listen?

Don't come near me. Don't go missing.

And in the lissome light of evening:

Help me, Cosmia; I'm grieving.

And all those lonely nights

down by the river,

Brought me bread and water

(Water, in.);

But though I tried so hard,

my little darlin,

I couldn't keep the night from coming in.

And all those lonely nights

down by the river

Brought me bread and water

by the kith and the kin;

Now in the quiet hour,

when I am sleeping,

I cannot keep the night from coming in.

*

Beneath the porch-light

we've all been circling.

Beat our dust hearts;

singe our flour wings.

But in the corner,
something is happening!
Wild Cosmia, what have you seen?

Water were your limbs,
and the fire was your hair -
and then the moonlight caught your eye,
And you rose through the air
well, if you've seen true light,
then this is my prayer:

will you call me, when you get there?

And I miss your precious heart;
And I miss your precious heart;
and miss, and miss, and miss,
& miss, & miss, &
miss, & miss, & miss your heart.

But release your precious heart,
to its feast, for precious hearts.

Have One On Me - 1 - Easy

Easy, easy.

My man and me,
we could rest and remain here, easily.
We are tested and pained
by what's beyond our bed.
We are blessed and sustained
by what is not said.

No-one knows what is coming, or
who will harvest what we have sown,
or how I've been dulling, and dumbing,
in the service of the heart alone,

or how I am worn to the bone
by the river,
and, in the river made of light,
I'm your little life-giver.
I will give my life.

Haven't you seen what I've seen?
Don't you know what you ought to do?
I was born to love,
and I intend to love you.

Down in the valley,
where the fields are green,
Watch my luck turn, fro and to;
pluck every last daisy clean,
till only I may love you.

I am easy,
easy to keep.
Honey, you please me
even in your sleep.
But my arms want to carry.
My heart wants to hold.
Tell me your worries. I want to be told.

Sit, and see how the fog,
from the port in the bay,

lays like snow
at the foot of the roanoke;

hear the frog, going courting,
till the day he croaks,
saying, even then,
How there is light in the river.
And there's a river made of light.
C'mon, you little life-giver.
Give your life.

Who asked you?
Asked you
if you want to be loved by me?
Who died, and made you in charge
of who loves who?

All the livelong day,
if I have my way, I will love you.
But One can't carry the weight,
or change the fate, of Two.
I've been waiting for a break.
How long's it gonna take?
Let me love you.
How about it?
How about what I have to say?
How about that livelong day?
How am I gonna stay here
without you?

Easy, easy.
You must not fear.
You must meet me, to see me.
I am barely here.
But, like a Bloody Mary,
seen in the mirror:
speak my name
and I appear.

Speak my name
and I appear.
Speak
and I appear.

Have One On Me - 2 - Have One on Me

From the courtyard, I floated in
and watched it go down.
Heard the cup drop;
thought, "Well,
that's why they keep them around."
The blackguard sat hard, down,
with no head on him now,
and I felt so bad,
cause I didn't know how
to feel bad enough
to make him proud.

By the time you read this,
I will be so far away.
Daddy longlegs, how in the world
am I to be expected to stay?
In the night -
in the night, you may hear me call
Pa, stay your hand
and steel your resolve.
Stay where you are,
so long and tall.

Here's Lola - ta da! - to do
her famous Spider Dance for you!
Lighten up your pockets!
Shake her skirts and scatter, there,
a shrieking, six-legged millionaire
with a blight in his sockets.

Miss Montez,
the Countess of Lansfeld,
appealed to the King of Bavaria,
saying, "Pretty papa,
if you are my friend -
mister daddy longlegs, they are at it again! -
Can I see you?"

Poor Lola! A tarantula's mounting
Countess Lansfeld's

handsome brassiere,
while they all cheer.

And the old king fell from grace,
while Lola fled,
To save face and her career

You caught a fly, floating by,
Wait for him to drown in the dust;
drown in the dust of other flies,
whereby the machine is run,
and the deed is done.
Heaven has no word
for the way you and your friends
have treated poor Louis.
May god save your poor soul, Lola.
(But there is nothing I adore,
apart from that whore's black heart.)

Well, doesn't that just beat all!
Miss Gilbert,
called to Castlemaine
by the silver dollar and the gold glitter!
Well, I've seen lots,
but never, in a million years,
would think to see you, here.

Though the long road
begins and ends with you,
I cannot seem to make amends
with you, Louis.
When we go out,
they're bound to see you with me.

At night, I walk in the park,
with a whip,
between the lines
of the whispering Jesuits,
who are poisoning you against me.
There's a big black spider
hanging over my door.
Can't go anywhere, anymore.
Tell me, are you with me?

I called to you, several times,
while the change took place
and then arrived, all night,
and I died.
But all these songs,
when you and I are long gone,
will carry on.
Mud in your eye.

You asked my hand,
hired a band.
"In your heart is all that you need;
ask and you will receive," it is said.
I threw my bouquet,
and I knocked 'em dead.

Bottle of white, bottle of red.
Helpless as a child,
when you held me in your arms,
and I knew that no other
could ever love me as you loved.
Love me as you loved.
But help me! I'm leaving!

I remember everything,
down to the sound of you shaving -
the scrape of your razor,
the dully-abrading black hair
that remained
when you clutched at me,
that night I came upstairs, half-dead,
and, in your kindness,
you put me straightaway
in the cupboard,
with a bottle of champagne,
and then, later, on a train.

It was dark out, I was half-dead.
I saw a star fall into the sky,
like a chunk of thrown coal,
as if god himself spat
like a cornered rat.

I really want you to do this for me,
will you have one on me?

It was dark; I was drunk and half-dead,
and we slept, knocking heads,
sitting up in the star-smoking air,
knocking heads like buoys.

Don't you worry for me!
Will you have one on me!

Meanwhile, I will raise my own glass
to how you made me fast
and expendable,
and I will drink to your excellent health,
and your cruelty.
Will you have one on me?

- helpless as a child,
when you held me in your arms,
and I knew that no other
could ever love me -

From the courtyard, I floated in
and watched it go down.
Heard the cup drop;
thought, "Well, that's why
they keep them around."
The blackguard sat hard, down,
with no head on him now,
and I felt so bad,
cause I didn't know how
to feel bad enough
to make him proud.

Well daddy longlegs, are you?
Daddy longlegs, are you?
Daddy longlegs, are you proud?

Have One On Me - 3 - '81

I found a little plot of land,
in the garden of Eden.
It was dirt, and dirt is all the same.
I tilled it with my two hands,
and I called it my very own;
there was no-one to dispute my claim.

Well, you'd be shocked
at the state of things -
the whole place
had just cleared right out.
It was hotter'n hell,
so I laid me by a spring, for a spell,
as naked as a trout.

The wandering eye that I have caught
is as hot as a wandering sun.
But I will want for nothing more,
in my garden:
start again,
in my hardening to every heart but one.

Meet me in the garden of Eden.
Bring a friend.
We are gonna have ourselves a time.
We are gonna have a garden party.
It's on me!
No, sirree, it's my dime.
We broke our hearts,
in the war between
St. George and the dragon,
but both, in equal parts,
are welcome to come along.
I'm inviting everyone.

Farewell to loves that I have known,
Even muddiest waters run.
Tell me, what is meant by sin, or none,
in a garden
seceded from the union

in the year of A.D. 1?

The unending amends you've made
are enough for one life.

Be done.

I believe in innocence, little darling.

Start again.

I believe in everyone.

I believe, regardless.

I believe in everyone.

Have One On Me - 4 - Good Intentions Paving Company

Twenty miles left to the show.
Hello, my old country. Hello.
Stars are just beginning to appear,
and I have never, in my life,
before been here.

And it's my heart, not me,
who cannot drive,
at which conclusion you arrived,
watching me sit here, bolt upright,
and cry for no good reason
at the Eastering sky.

And the tilt of this strange nation,
and the will to remain for the duration
(waving the flag,
feeling it drag).
Like a bump on a bump on a log, baby;
like I'm in a fistfight with the fog, baby;
step, ball-change, and a-pirouette!

And I regret, I regret
how I said to you,
Honey, just open your heart,
when I've got trouble
even opening a honey jar.
And that, right there, is where we are.

And I've been 'fessing, double-fast,
addressing questions nobody asked.
I'll get this joy off of my chest, at last,
and I will love you
till the noise has long since passed.

And I did not mean to shout, Just drive,
Just get us out, dead or alive.
The road's too long to mention -
Lord, it's something to see! -
laid down by the
Good Intentions Paving Company,

all the way to the thing
we've been playing at, darling.
I can see that you're wearing
your staying-hat, darling.

And for the time being, all is well.
Won't you love me a spell?
This is blindness, beyond all conceiving,
while behind us, the road is leaving,
and leaving, and falling back
like a rope gone slack.

And, I saw straightaway
that the lay was steep,
but I fell for you, honey,
easy as falling asleep.
And that, right there,
is the course I keep.

And no amount of talking
is going to soften the fall,
but, like after the rain,
step out of the overhang. That's all.
It had a nice ring to it,
when the old opry house rang,
so, with a solemn auld lang
syne, sealed, delivered,
I sang.

And there is hesitation,
and it always remains
(concerning you, me,
and the rest of the gang),
and, in our quiet hour,
I feel I see everything,
and am in love
with the hook
upon which everyone hangs.

And I know you meant
to show the extent
to which you gave a goddang -
you ranged real hot and real cold,

but I'm sold,
I am at home on that range.
And I do hate to fold,
right here, at the top of my game,
when I've been trying
with my whole heart and soul
to stay right here, in the right lane.
But it can make you feel over, and old
(Lord, you know it's a shame),
when I only want for you to pull over,
and hold me,
till I can't remember my own name.

Have One On Me - 5 - No Provenance

Allelu, allelu:

I have died happy,
and lived to tell the tale to you.
I have slept for forty years,
and woke to find me gone.
I woke safe and warm in your arms.
In your arms, your arms,
in your arms.

Not informed of the natural law,
squatting, lordly, on a stool, in a stall,
we spun gold clear out of straw.
And, when our bales of bullion
were stored,
you burned me like a barn.
I burned safe and warm in your arms.
In your arms, your arms.

I'm afraid of the Big Return.
There's a certain conversation lost,
and that loss incurred
with nobody remaining,
to register who had passed this way,
in the night,
in the middle of the night
(negating their grace and their sight),
till only I remember, or mark,
how we had our talk:

We took our ride,
so that there was no-one home,
and the lights of Rome
flickered and died.
And, what's more,
I believe that you knew it, too;
I think you saw their flares,
and kept me safely unawares,
in your arms.
Your arms, in your arms.

The grass was tall, and strung with burrs,
I essayed that high sashay which,
in my mind, was my way;
you hung behind, in yours.
Anyhow, she did not neigh.
I do not know
what drew our eyes to hers;
that little black mare did not stir,
till I lay down in your arms.

Poor old dirty little dog-size horse! -
swaying and wheezing,
as a matter of course;
swaying and wheezing,
as a matter of pride.
That poor old nag, not four palms wide,
had waited a long time,
coated in salt,
buckled like a ship run foul of the fence.
And in the middle of the night,
she'd sprung up,
no provenance,
bearing the whites of her eyes.

And you, with your
'arrangement' with Fate,
nodded sadly at her lame assault
on that steady old gate,
her faultlessly etiolated fishbelly-face;
the muzzle of a ghost.

And, pretty Johnny Appleseed,
via satellite feed,
tell us, who was it
that you then loved the most?
Pretty Johnny Appleseed,
leave a trail that leads
straight back down to the farm.
Lay me down
safe and warm in your arms.
In your arms.

Have One On Me - 6 - Baby Birch

This is the song for Baby Birch.
I will never know you.
And at the back of what we've done,
there is that knowledge of you.

Well I wish we could take every path.
I could spend a hundred years
adoring you.
Yes, I wish we could take every path,
because you know I hated to close
the door on you.

Do you remember staring,
up at the stars,
so far away in their bulletproof cars?
We heard the rushing, slow intake
of the dark, dark water,
and the engine breaks,
and I said,

How about them engine breaks?
And, if I should die before I wake,
will you keep an eye on Baby Birch?
Because I'd hate to see her
make the same mistakes.

When it was dark,
I called and you came.
When it was dark, I saw shapes.
When I see stars, I feel, in your hand,
and I see stars,
and I reel, again.

Well mercy me. I'll be goddamned.
It's been a long, long time
since I last saw you.
And I have never known the plan.
It's been a long, long time.
How are you?
Your eyes are green. Your hair is gold.

Your hair is black. Your eyes are blue.
I closed the ranks, and I doubled back -
but, you know, I hated to close
the doggone door on you.

We take a walk along the dirty lake.
Hear the goose,
cussing at me over her eggs.
You poor little cousin.
I don't want your dregs
(A little baby fussing over my legs).

There is a blacksmith,
and there is a shepherd,
and there is a butcher-boy,
and there is a barber, who's cutting
and cutting away at my only joy.
I saw a rabbit,
as slick as a knife,
and as pale as a candlestick,
and I had thought it'd be harder to do,
but I caught her, and skinned her quick:
held her there,
kicking and mewling,
upended, unspooling, unsung and blue;
told her "wherever you go,
little runaway bunny,
I will find you."
And then she ran,
as they're liable to do.

Be at peace baby, and be gone.
Be at peace baby, and be gone.

Have One On Me - 7 - On a Good Day

Hey hey hey, the end is near!
On a good day,
you can see the end from here.
But I won't turn back, now,
though the way is clear;
I will stay for the remainder.

I saw a life, and I called it mine.
I saw it, drawn so sweet and fine,
and I had begun to fill in all the lines,
right down to what we'd name her.

Our nature does not change by will.
In the winter, 'round the ruined mill,
the creek is lying, flat and still;
it is water,
though it's frozen.

So, 'cross the years,
and miles, and through,
on a good day,
you can feel my love for you.
Will you leave me be,
so that we can stay true
to the path that you have chosen?

Have One On Me - 8 - You and Me, Bess

We picked our way
down to the beach,
watching the waves
dragging out of our reach:
tangling tails, like a sodden sheet;
dangling entrails
from the gut of the sea.

Hoarding our meals (alfalfa and rolls);
trying not to catch
the cold eye of the gulls -
I hope Mother Nature has not
overheard!
(Though, she doles out hurt
like a puking bird.)

We stayed for the winter.
No-one told us
about the laws of the land.
I hold my own.
But you, with your hunger -
you, on the other hand -
make yourself known.

And when we were found,
I know we both grieved.
My heart made the sound of
snow falling from eaves.
You and me, Bess,
we was as thick as thieves.
So I swore, nonetheless, up and down,
it was only me.
So they took me away,
and, after some time
studying my case,
must have made up their minds.
By the time you realized I was dying,
must have been too late.
I believe you were not lying.

It is the day.
I wake,
with my ears cocked up like a gun
(like every day, of course),
yanked by my wrists
to the sugar-front courtyard -
now tell me, what have I done?
seems I have stolen a horse.
and I step to the gallows.

Who do you think that you are -
arching your hooves like a crane,
in the shallow gutter
that lines the boulevards,
crowded with folks
who just stare as I hang?
It's all the same.
Kindness comes over me;
what was your name?
It makes no difference.
I'm glad that you came.
Forever, I'll listen to your glad neighing.

Have One On Me - 9 - In California

My heart became a drunken runt
on the day I sunk in this shunt,
to tap me clean
of all the wonder
and the sorrow I have seen,
since I left my home:

My home, on the old Milk Lake,
where the darkness does fall so fast,
it feels like some kind of mistake
(just like they told you it would;
just like the Tulgeywood).

When I came into my land,
I did not understand:
neither dry rot, nor the burn pile,
nor the bark-beetle, nor the dry well,
nor the black bear.

But there is another,
who is a little older.
When I broke my bone,
he carried me up from the riverside.

To spend my life
in spitting-distance
of the love that I have known,
I must stay here, in an endless eventide.

And if you come and see me,
you will upset the order.
You cannot come and see me,
for I set myself apart.
But when you come and see me,
in California,
you cross the border of my heart.

Well, I have sown untidy furrows
across my soul,
but I am still a coward,

content to see my garden grow
so sweet & full
of someone else's flowers.

Sometimes
I can almost feel the power.
Sometimes I am so in love with you
(like a little clock
that trembles on the edge of the hour,
only ever calling out "Cuckoo, cuckoo").

When I called you,
you, little one,
in a bad way,
did you love me?
Do you spite me?
Time will tell if I can be well,
and rise to meet you rightly.
While, moving across my land,
brandishing themselves
like a burning branch,
advance the tallow-colored,
walleyed deer,
quiet as gondoliers,
while I wait all night, for you,
in California,
watching the fox pick off my goldfish
from their sorry, golden state -
and I am no longer
afraid of anything, save
the life that, here, awaits.

I don't belong to anyone.
My heart is heavy as an oil drum.
I don't want to be alone.
My heart is yellow as an ear of corn,
and I have torn my soul apart, from
pulling artlessly with fool commands.

Some nights
I just never go to sleep at all,
and I stand,
shaking in my doorway like a sentinel,

all alone,
bracing like the bow upon a ship,
and fully abandoning
any thought of anywhere
but home,
my home.
Sometimes I can almost feel the power.
And I do love you.
Is it only timing,
that has made it such a dark hour,
only ever chiming out,
"Cuckoo, cuckoo"?

My heart, I wear you down, I know.
Gotta think straight,
keep a clean plate;
keep from wearing down.
If I lose my head,
just where am I going to lay it?

(For it has half-ruined me,
to be hanging around,
here, among the daphne,
blooming out of the big brown;
I am native to it, but I'm overgrown.
I have choked my roots
on the earth, as rich as roe,
here,
down in California.)

Have One On Me - 10 - Jackrabbits

I was tired of being drunk.
My face cracked like a joke.
So I swung through here
like a brace of jackrabbits,
with their necks all broke.

I stumbled at the door with my boot,
and I knocked against the jamb.
and I scrabbled at your chest, like a mute,
with my fists of ham.
trying to tell you that I am
telling you I can -
I can
love you again;
love you again.

I'm squinting towards the East.
My faith makes me a dope.
But you can take my hand,
in the darkness, darling,
like a length of rope.
I shaped up overnight, you know,
the day after she died.
when I saw my heart,
and I'll tell you, darling,
it was open wide.
what with telling you I am
telling you I can -
I can
love you again;
love you again.

And it can have no bounds, you know.
It can have no end.
You can take my hand
in the darkness, darling,
when you need a friend.
And it can change in shape or form,
but never change in size.
Well the water, it ran deep, my darling,

where it don't run wide.

The feather of a hawk was bound,
bound around my neck;
a poultice made of fig,
the eager little vultures pecked.
And a verse I read in jest
in Matthew, spoke to me;
said There's a flame that moves
like a low-down pest
and says, You will be free

only, tell me that I can
tell me that I can:
I can love you again;
love you again.

Love you again, love you again.
Love you again, love you again.
Love you again, love you again.
Love you again, love you again.
Love you again, love you...

Have One On Me - 11 - Go Long

Last night, again,
you were in my dream.
Several expendable limbs were at stake.
You were a prince, spinning rims,
all sentiments indian-given
and half-baked.
I was brought
in on a palanquin
made of the many bodies
of beautiful women.
Brought to this place, to be examined,
swaying on an elephant:
a princess of India.

We both want the very same thing.
We are praying
I am the one to save you.
But you don't even own
your own violence.
Run away from home -
your beard is still blue
with the loneliness of you mighty men,
with your jaws, and fists, and guitars,
and pens, and your sugarlip,
but I've never been to the firepits
with you mighty men.

Who made you this way?
Who made you this way?
Who is going to bear
your beautiful children?
Do you think you can just stop,
when you're ready for a change?
Who will take care of you
when you're old and dying?

You burn in the Mekong,
to prove your worth.
Go long! Go long!
Right over the edge of the earth!

You have been wronged,
tore up since birth.
You have done harm.
Others have done worse.

Will you tuck your shirt?
Will you leave it loose?
You are badly hurt.
You're a silly goose.

You are caked in mud,
and in blood, and worse.
Chew your bitter cud.
Grope your little nurse.

Do you know why
my ankles are bound in gauze?
(sickly dressage:
a princess of Kentucky)?
In the middle of the woods
(which were the probable cause),
we danced in the lodge
like two panting monkeys.

I will give you a call, for one last hurrah.
And if this tale is tall, forgive my scrambling.
But you keep palming along the wall,
moving at a blind crawl,
but always rambling.

Wolf-spider, crouch in your funnel nest.
If I knew you, once,
now I know you less.
In the sinking sand,
where we've come to rest,
have I had a hand in your loneliness?

When you leave me alone
in this old palace of yours,
it starts to get to me. I take to walking.
What a woman does is open doors.
And it is not a question of locking
or unlocking.

Well, I have never seen
such a terrible room -
gilded with the gold teeth
of the women who loved you!
Now, though I die,
Magpie, this I bequeath:
by any other name,
a Jay is still blue

with the loneliness
of you mighty men,
with your mighty kiss
that might never never end,
while, so far away,
in the seat of the West,
burns the fount
of the heat
of that loneliness.

There's a man
who only will speak in code,
backing slowly, slowly down the road.
May he master everything
that such men may know
about loving, and then letting go.

Have One On Me - 12 - Occident

Mercy me, the night is long.
Take my pen, to write you this song.

Lord: is it harder to carry on,
or to know when you are done?

All my life, I've felt as though
I'm inside a beautiful memory,
replaying
with the sound turned down low.

Long-life, show your face.
Slow-heart, curb your taste.
Smoke me out of my hiding place.
Long-life, state your case.

What in the world are we waiting for -
building glowing cities along the shore,
where the wind batters in,
baiting my kin like a matador?

So much value, placed upon
what lies just beyond our plans:
waving my handkerchief,
running along, till the end of the sand.

Long-life, speak your name.
So tired of the guessing game.
But, something is moving,
just out of frame:
Slow-heart,
brace and aim.

Breaching slowly, across the sea,
one mast -
a flash, like the stinger of a bee -
to take you away,
a swarming fleet is gonna take you
from me.

The universe is getting loose:
sodden spread,
from some leaden disuse,
rushing, unhinged,
toward diminishing lights,
like a headless caboose.

I'll wait for you,
alongside the ocean,
and make do
with my no-skin.
But then, Long-life,
will you let me in?
And then, Slow-heart,
are you gonna know him?
Long-life, speak your name.
I wait, while I decry the wait.
And when I die, may I relate:
Slow heart, congregate.

To leave your home, and your family,
for some distortion of property?
Well, darling, I can't go.
But you may stay
here, with me.

Have One On Me - 13 - Soft as Chalk

So, so long ago,
and so far away,
when Time was just a line
that you fed me,
when you wanted to stay,

we'd talk
as soft as chalk,
till morning came, pale as a pearl:

No time!
No time!
Now, I have got all the time
in the world.

Say, honey, did you belong to me?
Tell me, honey,
was your heart at rest when, darlin,
all the mourning doves were howling us
a song of love's
godawful lawlessness? Lawlessness.
Say, honey, did you belong to me?
Tell me, honey, did I pass your test?
I lay, as still as death, until the dawn,
whereupon I wrested from
your godawful lawlessness. Lawlessness.

I roam around the tidy grounds
of my dappled sanatorium.
Coatless, I sit
amongst the motes, adrift,
and I dote upon my pinesap gum.
And the light, through the pines,
in brassy tines,
lays over me, dim as rum
and thick as molasses.
And so time passes.
And so, my heart, tomorrow comes.

I feel you, leaning,

out back with the crickets,
loyal heart marking the soon-ness,
darkness:
tonight, still,
the mourning doves
will summon us their song
of love's neverdoneing lawlessness, lawlessness

while, over and over -
rear up! stand down! lay round! -
trying to sound-out,
or guess the reasons,
I sleep like a soldier, without rest.
But there is no treason,
where there is only lawlessness. Lawlessness.

In the last week
of the last year I was aware,
I took a blind shot, across the creek,
at the black bear,
when he roused me in the night,
and left me cowering with my light,
calling out
Who is there?
Who's there?
Who is there?

I watched you sleep,
repeating my prayer.
(You give love a little shove
and it becomes terror.)
And now I am calling,
in a sadness beyond anger
and beyond fear,
Who is there? Who's there?
Who is there?

I glare and nod,
like the character, God,
bearing down
upon the houses and lawns.
I knew a little bit,
but, darling, you were it,

and, darling, now it is long gone.
Sweetheart, in your clean, bright start -
back there, behind a hill, and a dell,
and a state line or two -
I'll be thinking of you.
Yes, I'll be thinking,
and be wishing you well.
We land, I stand,
But I wait for the sound of the bell.
I have to catch a cab,
and my bags are at the carousel.
And then - Lord, just then -
time alone will only tell.

You mourning dove.

Have One On Me - 14 - Esme

I can feel a difference.
Today, a difference:
all of us, in our tents,
fearing god like a mistress.

We lay on the rocks, in the sun,
watching you and your mama row in,
I sat up and blinked,
when you appeared,
so pale you were nearly clear!

Later, I stumbled to my bed,
all alone in the branches.
I laid in the dark,
thinking about all of my friends,
and their changes.

And I do not know
if you know just what you have done.
You are the sweetest one
I have ever laid my eyes upon.

It's a beautiful town,
with the rain coming down.
Blackberry, rosemary,
jimmy-crack-corn.
You've got the run of the place,
now that you're running around;
and may kindness,
kindness, kindness abound.

In this hour of our lives -
hour of effortless plenty -
how do we know
which parts of our hearts want what,
with such base generosity?

Taking so many photographs -
so amazed! -
we've never seen a baby so newlyborn.

And, when the bulbs do flash,
as bright as morning,
the crowd keeps on gathering
like an electric storm.

The phantom of love
moves among us at will.
Each phantom-limb lost,
has got an angel
(so confused,
like the wagging bobbed-tail
of a bulldog):
kindness, kindness prevails.

Kindness prevails!
Ties and rails, ties and rails fall into line,
bearing kindness.
Where will you go, if not here?
What will you say,
when you write to us?

And this is a world of terrible hardship,
everywhere,
and I search for words
to set you at ease.
But there, in the looking-glass,
a kite is soaring,
stilling my warring heart
and my trembling knees.

Clean as a breeze,
bright as the day:
all of the people gather to say:
"Sweet Esme! Sweet Esme!
Oh, oh, oh!"

I believe love will always surround you -
brave as a bear,
with a heart rare and true.
But if you are scared,
if you are blue,
I have prepared this small song for you:
Sweet Esme! Sweet Esme!

Oh, oh, oh!

Sweet Esme! Sweet Esme!

Oh, oh, oh!

Sweet Esme! Esme!

Sweet Esme! Sweet Esme!

Oh, oh, oh!

Have One On Me - 15 - Autumn

Driven through by her own sword,
summer died last night, alone.
Even the ghosts
huddled up for warmth.
Autumn has come to my hometown.

Friendly voices, dead and gone,
singing, Star of the country down...
(even the ghosts help raise the barn,
here, now, in my hometown)

- when, out of the massing
that bodes and bides, in the cold west,
flew a waxwing, who froze
and died against my breast!
And all the while, rain,
like a weed in the tide,
swans and lists, down
on the gossiping lawns,
saying tsk tsk tsk.

I may have changed. It's hard to gauge.
Time won't account for how I've aged.
Would I could tie your lying tongue,
who says that leaving keeps you young.

And I have got no control
over my heart, over my mind.
Over the hills, the rainclouds roll.
I'll winter here, wait for a sign

to cast myself
out, over the water,
riven like a wishbone.
You'd hardly guess
I was my own mother's daughter;
I ain't naturally given to roam.
And I lay low, when I return,
and I move
like a gurney

whose wheels are squeaking,
alone, here in my home,
and I laugh,
when you speak of my
pleasure-seeking
among the tall pines,
along the lay-lines.
Here, where the loon keens.
There, where the moon leans.
There,
where I know my violent love lays down,
in a row of silent, dove-gray days.
Here, in a row of silent, dove-gray days.

Wherever I go, I am snowbound
by thoughts of him
whom I would shun.
I loved them all,
one by one.
Cannot gain ground,
cannot outrun;
but time marches along.
You can't always stick around.
But, when the final count is done,
I will be in my hometown.
I will be in my hometown.

Have One On Me - 16 - Ribbon Bows

There is a spring, not far from here,
The water runs both sweet and clear -
both sweet and clear, and cold:
could crack your bones
with veins of gold.

I stood, a-wagging, at the tap;
just a-waiting on the lagging, rising sap.
I held the cold tin ladle to my lip.
At the Shrine of the Thousand Arms,
I lowered my eyes to sip.

What a beautiful day to catch my drift,
or be caught up in it.
You want your love, Love?
Come and get your love;
I only took it back
because I thought you didn't.

How my ears did ring,
at the municipal pound,
from that old hangdog
to which I was bound:
curled 'round the bottom rung -
doesn't nobody want you?
Well, come on, darlin.
I could use someone like you around.
I am not like you, I ain't from this place.
And I do reserve the right
to repeat all my same mistakes.
And, in the night, like you,
I certainly bite and chew
what I can find,
and never seem to lose the taste.

What a horrible face I feel me make -
For Pete's sake,
what you have told me, I cannot erase! -
(Though I keep on saying,
and I do believe, it is not too late).

All day, you're hassling me with trifles:
black nose of the dog, as cold as a rifle,
indicating, with a nudge,
God, No God. God, No God.
Sweet, appraising eye of the dog,
blink once if god,
twice if no god.

My mama may be ashamed of me,
with all of my finery:
carrying on,
whooping it up till the early morn,
lost and lorn,
among the madding revelry!
Sure, I can pass.
Honey, I can pass.
Particularly when I start to tip my glass.
I'll be a sport,
and have a go at that old song,
singing unabashed, about
'Them city girls,
with their ribbon bows,
and their fancy sash...'

But, though I get so sad
(could swear the night
makes a motion to claim me,
around that second verse),
I reckon I've felt worse,
and still held fast.
But, later on, when I am alone,
alone at last,
well I take my god to task.
I take my daggone god to task.

Have One On Me - 17 - Kingfisher

Whose is the hand that I will hold?
Whose is the face I will see?
Whose is the name that I will call,
when I am called to meet thee?

In this life, who did you love,
beneath the drifting ashes,
beneath the sheeting banks of air
that barrenly bore our rations?

When I could speak, it was too late.
Didn't you hear me calling?
Didn't you see my heart leap,
like a pup in the constant barley?

In this life, where did you crouch,
when the sky had set to boiling?
Burning within, seen from without,
and your gut was a serpent, coiling.

And, for the sake of that pit of snakes,
for whom did you allay your shyness,
and spend all your mercy,
and madness, and grace,
in a day, beneath the bending cypress?

It was not on principal.
Show, Pro-heart, that you have got gall.
A miracle:
I can bear a lot, but not that pall.

I can bear a lot, but not that pall!
Kingfisher, sound the alarm.
Say, "Sweet little darlin, now,
come to my arms;
tell me all about the love
you left on the farm."

He was a kind, unhurried man
with a heavy lip and a steady hand,

but he loved me just like a little child;
like a little child loves a little lamb.

Thrown to the ground,
by something down there;
bitten by the bad air,
while the clouds tick;
trying to read all the signs,
preparing for when the bombs hit;
hung from the underbelly of the earth,
while the stars skid away, below,
gormless and brakeless, gravel-loose,
falling silent as gavels in the snow

I lay back and spit my chaw,
wrapped in the long arm of the Law,
who has seen it all:
I can bear a lot, but not that pall.

I can bear a lot, but not that pall!
Kingfisher, cast your fly:
oh, Lord,
it happens without even trying,
when I sling a low look
from my shuttering eye.

Blows rain upon the one you loved,
and, though you were only sparring,
there's blood on the eye.
Unlace the glove.
Say, Honey I am not sorry.

Stand here and name
the one you loved,
beneath the drifting ashes,
and, in naming, rise above time,
as it, flashing, passes.

We came by the boatload,
and were immobilized:
worshipping volcanoes,
charting the loping skies.
The tides of the earth

left us bound, and calcified,
and made as obstinate as obsidian,
unmoving, save our eyes:
just mooning and blinking
from faces marked with coal.
(Ash cooling and shrinking
cracks loud as thunder rolling.)
I swear I know you. You know me.
Where have we met before?
Tell me true:
to whose authority
do you consign your soul?

I had a dream you came to me,
said
You shall not do me harm anymore,
and with your knife,
you evicted my life
from its little lighthouse
on the seashore.

And I saw that my blood
had no bounds,
spreading in a circle like an atom bomb,
soaking and felling
everything in its path,
and welling in my heart like a birdbath.

It is too short -
the day we are born,
we commence with our dying.
Trying to serve,
with the heart of a child;
kingfisher, lie with the lion.

Have One On Me - 18 - Does Not Suffice

I will pack up my pretty dresses.
I will box up my high-heeled shoes.
A sparkling ring, for every finger,
I'll put away, and hide from view.

Coats of bouclé, jacquard and cashmere;
cartouche and tweed, all silver shot -
and everything that could remind you
of how easy I was not.

I'll tuck away my gilded buttons;
I'll bind my silks in shapeless bales;
Wrap it all on up, in reams of tissue,
and then I'll kiss you, sweet, farewell.

You saw me rise to our occasion,
and so deny the evidence.
Caused me to burn, and twist,
and grimace against you,
like something caught
on a barbed-wire fence.

Now, you can see me fall back here,
redoubled,
full bewildered and amazed.
I have gotten into some terrible trouble,
beneath your blank and rinsing gaze.

It does not suffice
for you to say I am a sweet girl,
or to say you hate to see me sad
because of you.
It does not suffice,
to merely lie beside each other,
as those who love each other do.

I picture you, rising up in the morning:
stretching out on your boundless bed,
beating a clear path to the shower,
scouring yourself red.

The tap of hangers,
swaying in the closet -
unburdened hooks
and empty drawers -
and everywhere I tried to love you
is yours again,
and only yours.

Divers - 1 - Anecdotes

Sending the first scouts over,
back from the place beyond the dawn:
Horse, bear your broken soldier,
eyes frozen wide at what went on.

And Time, in our camp, is moving
as you'd anticipate it to.
But what is this sample proving?
Anecdotes cannot say what Time may do.

I kid with Rufous Nightjar,
when our men are all asleep:
"It ain't about how rare you are,
but how hard you are to see.
Take, you and me-"

"When are you from?" said he,
in our blind of winter leaves,
as we sighted out their fliers
in the grayscale of the night
fumbled on the bare ground
to bury round landmines,
while the dew lay down and dried.

We signal Private Poorwill, when morning starts to loom:
"Pull up from your dive!"
till we hear the telltale Boom,
too soon-
hotdogging loon, caught there
like a shard of mirror in the moon!

Now they've stopped giving orders,
but I follow anyway,
laying in our state of torpor,
waiting out the day
while the dew burns away.

Rushing, tearing, speeding home:
bound to a wheel that is not my own,
where round every bend I long to see

temporal infidelity.

And all along the road, the lights stream by.
I want to go where the dew won't dry.
I want to go where the light won't bend-
far as the eye may reach-nor end.

But inasmuch as that light is loaned,
insofar as we've borrowed bones,
must every debt now be repaid
in star-spotted, sickle-winged night raids,
while we sing to the garden, and we sing to the stars,
and we sing in the meantime,
wherever you are?

In the folds and the branches,
somewhere, out there,
I was only just born into open air.
Now hush, little babe.
You don't want to be
down in the trenches,
remembering with me,

where you will not mark my leaving,
and you will not hear my parting song.
Nor is there cause for grieving.
Nor is there cause for carrying on.

-and daughter, when you are able,
come down and join! The kettle's on,
and your family's round the table.
Will you come down, before the sun is gone?

Divers - 2 - Sapokanikan

The cause is Ozymandian.
The map of Sapokanikan
is sanded and beveled,
the land lone and leveled
by some unrecorded and powerful hand
which plays along the monument,
and drums, upon a plastic bag,
The Brave Men and Women, So Dear to God
and Famous To All of the Ages rag.

(Sing: Do you love me?
Will you remember?
The snow falls above me.
The Renderer, renders.
The Event is in the hand of God.)

Beneath a Patch of Grass,
her bones the old Dutch master hid,
while, elsewhere, Tobias and the Angel disguised
what the scholars surmised was a mother and kid
(interred with other daughters, in dirt, in other potter's fields).
Above them,
parades mark the passing of days
through parks where pale colonnades arch
in marble and steel,
where all of the Twenty Thousand attending your foot fall
(and the Cause that they died for)
are lost in the idling birdcalls,
and the records they left are cryptic at best,
lost in obsolescence:

the text will not yield
(nor X-ray reveal, with any fluorescence)
where the Hand of the Master begins and ends.

I fell.
I tried to do well, but I won't be.
Will you tell the one that I loved
to remember, and hold me?
I call and call for the doctor,

but the snow swallows me whole,
with old Florry Walker.

The event lives only in print.

He said,
"It's alright, and it's all over now," and boarded the plane,
his belt unfastened,
(The boy was known to show unusual daring-
and called a 'boy', this alderman
confounding Tammany Hall, in whose employ
King Tamanend himself preceded John's fall!)

So we all raise a standard
to which the wise and honest soul may repair;
to which a hunter,
a hundred years from now,
may look, and despair, and see with wonder
the tributes we have left to rust in the park:
swearing that our hair stood on end,
to see John Purroy Mitchel depart for the Western Front,
where work might count.
All exeunt! All go out!
Await the hunter, to decipher the stone
(and what lies under, now).
The city is gone.
Look, and despair.
Look, and despair.

Divers - 3 - Leaving the City

Hay, and a clean stall,
and ivy on a garden wall,
and a sign saying Sold,
and an old coat
for the bad cold.

I believe in you.
Do you believe in me?
What do you want to do?
Are we leaving the city?

On the black road,
through the gold fields,
while the fields are plowed,
towards what we are allowed...

The bridle bends in idle hands
and slows our canter to a trot.
We mean to stop, in increments, but can't commit.
We post and sit, in impotence:
the harder you hit, the deeper the dent.
We seek our name.
We seek our fame, and our credentials
(paned in glass, trained to master incidentals).
Bleach our collar, leech our dollar from our cents:
the longer you live, the higher the rent.

Beneath the pale sky,
beside the red barn,
below the white clouds,
is all we are allowed.
Here, the light will seep,
and the scythe will reap,
and spirit will rend, in counting toward the end.

In December of that year,
the word came down that she was here.
The days grew shorter.
I was sure, if she came 'round,
I'd hold my ground. I'd endure.

But they'd alluded to a change
that came to pass,
and Spring, deranged,
weeping grass and sleepless,
broke herself upon my windowglass.

And I could barely breathe, for seeing
all the splintered light that leaked her fissures,
fleeing, launched in flight:
unstaunched daylight, brightly bleeding,
bleached the night with dawn, deleting,

in that high sun,
after our good run,
when the spirit bends
beneath knowing it must end.

And that is all I want here:
to draw my gaunt spirit to bow
beneath what I am allowed.
Beneath what I am allowed.

Divers - 4 - Goose Eggs

What we built, at the kiln that won't be stilled,
did not set well:

The old veil of desire,
like the vessels that we fired,
fell thin as eggshells.

And every season, somebody burns,
downtown, taking turns-
taking a bus, to take a train and just plain vamoose.
Now the wind blows coals over the hills. Honey,
I've been paying my bills,
but honey it's been a long time since I've come to any use.
And it hurt me bad, when I heard the news
that you'd got that call, and could not refuse.

(A goose, alone, I suppose, can know the loneliness of geese,
who never find their peace,
whether north, or south, or west, or east; west or east;
and I could never find my way
to being the kind of friend you seemed to need in me,
till the needing had ceased.)

Recently, a bottle of rye, and a friend, and me,
on our five loose legs,
had a ramble, and spoke
of the scrambling of broken hopes, and goose eggs,
and a stranger, long ago.
(Not you, honey! You, I know.)
We just spoke of broken hopes and old strangers.
Now the wind blows coals over the sea. Tell you what, honey:
you and me better run and see if we can't contain them, first.

But you had somewhere that you had to go,
and you caught that flight out of Covalo.
Now, overhead, you're gunning in those Vs,
where you had better find your peace,
whether north, or south, or west, or east. West, or east.
And I had better find my way
to being the kind of friend you seemed to need in me,

at last (at least).

What's redacted will repeat,
and you cannot learn that you burn when you touch the heat,
so we touch the heat,
and we cut facsimiles of love and death
(just separate holes in sheets
where you cannot breathe, and you cannot see).

And I cannot now, for the life of me, believe our talk-
our flock had cause to leave,
but do we?
do we?

Divers - 5 - Waltz of the 101st Lightborne

I believed they had got what they came for;
I believed our peril was done,
on the eve of the last of the Great Wars,
after three we had narrowly won.
(But the fourth,
it was carelessly done.)

Saw his ship in its whistling ascension,
as they launched from the Capitol seat-
swear I saw our mistake
when the clouds draped like a flag,
across the backs of the fleet
of the Hundred-First Lightborne Elite.

As the day is long,
so the well runs dry,
and we came to see Time is taller
than Space is wide.
And we bade goodbye
to the Great Divide:
found unlimited simulacra to colonize!

But there was a time we were lashed to the prow
of a ship you may board, but not steer,
before You and I ceased to mean Now,
and began to mean only Right Here
(to mean Inches and Miles, but not Years);
before Space had a taste of its limits,
and a new sort of coordinate awoke,
making Time just another poor tenant:
bearing weight, taking fire, trading smokes,
in the war between us and our ghosts.

(But I saw the Bering Strait and the Golden Gate,
in silent suspension of their golden age!
And you can barely tell, if I guard it well,
where I have been, and seen,
pristine, unfelled.)

And I had a dream that I walked in the garden

of Chabot, and those telescope ruins.
It was there that I called to my true love,
who was pale as millennial moons,
Honey, where did you come by that wound?

When I woke, he was gone
and the War had begun,
in eternal return and repeat.
Calling, Where in the hell are the rest of your fellow
One Hundred-One Lightborne Elite?
stormed in the New Highland Light Infantry.

Make it stop, my love!
We were wrong to try.
Never saw what we could unravel,
in traveling light,
or how the trip debrides-
like a stack of slides!
All we saw was that Time is taller than Space is wide.

That's why we got bound to a round desert island,
'neath the sky where our sailors have gone.
Have they drowned, in those windy highlands?
Highlands away, my John.

Divers - 6 - The Things I Say

If I have the space of half a day,
I'm ashamed of half the things I say.
I'm ashamed to have turned out this way,
and I desire to make amends.

But it don't make no difference, now,
and no-one's listening, anyhow,
and lists of sins and solemn vows
don't make you any friends.

There's an old trick played,
when the light and the wine conspire
to make me think I'm fine.
I'm not, but I have got half a mind
to maybe get there, yet.

When the sky goes pink in Paris, France,
do you think of the girl who used to dance
when you'd frame her moving within your hands,
saying This I won't forget?

What happened to the man you were,
when you loved somebody before her?
Did he die?
Or does that man endure, somewhere far away?

Our lives come easy and our lives come hard.
And we carry them like a pack of cards:
some we don't use, but we don't discard,
but keep for a rainy day.

Divers - 7 - Divers

The diver is my love
(and I am his, if I am not deceived),
who takes one breath above, for every hour below the sea;
who gave to me a jewel
worth twice this woman's life (but would cost her less
than laying at low tide,
to see her true love phosphoresce).

And in an infinite regress:
Tell me, why is the pain of birth
lighter borne than the pain of death?
I ain't saying that I loved you first,
but I loved you best.

I know we must abide
each by the rules that bind us here:
the divers, and the sailors, and the women on the pier.
But how do you choose your form?
How do you choose your name? How do you choose your life?
How do you choose the time you must exhale,
and kick, and rise?

And in an infinite capsize:
Like a bull tearing down the coast,
double hulls bearing double masts-
I don't know if you loved me most, but you loved me last.

Recall the word you gave:
to count your way across the depths of this arid world,
where you would yoke the waves,
and lay a bed of shining pearls!
I dream it every night:
the ringing of the pail,
the motes of sand dislodged,
the shucking, quick and bright;
the twinned and cast-off shells reveal a single heart of white.

And in an infinite backslide:
Ancient border, sink past the West,
like a sword at the bearer's fall.

I can't claim that I knew you best,
but did you know me at all?

A woman is alive!
A woman is alive;
you do not take her for a sign in nacre on a stone,
alone, unfaceted and fine.
And never will I wed.
I'll hunt the pearl of death to the bottom of my life,
and ever hold my breath,
till I may be the diver's wife.

See how the infinite divides:
and the divers are not to blame
for the rift, spanning distant shores.
You don't know my name,
but I know yours.

Divers - 8 - Same Old Man

It's the same old lady, putting out the wash,
standing in the rain, in her mackintosh-
same old lady standing in the rain!
The thought of New York was going insane.

Hey little leaf, lying on the ground-
now you're turning slightly brown!
Why don't you come back on the tree,
turn the color green the way you ought to be?

My mind is failing, and my body grows weak.
And my lips won't form the words I speak.
And I'm floating away on a barrel of pain.
New York City won't see me again.

It's the same old man, sitting at the mill,
mill-wheel turning of its own free will.
I'm certainly glad to be at home.
New York City continues on, alone.

I'm certainly glad to be at home.
New York City continues on, alone.
New York City continues on, alone.
New York City continues...

Divers - 9 - You Will Not Take My Heart Alive

And what do you remember most?
The line of the sea, seceding the coast?
Fine capillaries, glowing with cars?
The comfort you drew from the light of the stars?

And how long did you climb that night,
with the ice in your lungs, on the rungs of the light?
Beyond recall, you severed all strings
to everyone, and everything.

Oh, silent, constant driver of mine:
wordlessly calling from the end of the line,
where, even though each hour I ever loved
must queue and dive,
still, you will not take my heart, alive.
You will not take my heart, alive.
You will not take my heart, alive.
You will not take my heart.

In martial wind, and in clarion rain,
we minced into battle, wincing in pain;
not meant for walking, backs bound in twine:
not angel or devil,
but level, in time.

And I rose, to take my shape at last,
from the dreams that had dogged me, through every past,
when, to my soul, the body would say
You may do what you like,
as long as you stay.

Now the towns and forests, highways and plains,
fall back in circles like an emptying drain.
And I won't come round this way again,
where the lonely wind abides,
and you will not take my heart, alive.
You will not take my heart, alive.
You will not take my heart, alive.
You will not take my heart, alive.
You will not take my heart, alive.

You will not take my heart, alive.
You will not take my heart, alive.
You will not take my heart.

Divers - 10 - A Pin-Light Bent

My life comes and goes.
My life comes and goes.
Short flight, free rows:
I lie down and doze.

My life came and went.
My life came and went.
Short flight; free descent.
Poor flight attendant.

But the sky, over the ocean!
And the ocean, skirting the city!
And the city, bright as a garden
(when the garden woke to meet me),
from that height was a honeycomb
made of light from those funny homes, intersected:
each enclosed, anelectric and alone.

In our lives is a common sense
that relies on the common fence
that divides, and attends,
but provides scant defense
from the Great Light that shines through a pin-hole,
when the pin-light calls itself Selfhood,
and the Selfhood inverts on a mirror
in an Amora Obscura.

But it's mine. Or, at least, it's lent.
And my life, until the time is spent
is a pin-light, bent.
It's a pin-light, bent.

Divers - 11 - Time, As a Symptom

Time passed hard,
and the task was the hardest thing she'd ever do.
But she forgot,
the moment she saw you.

So it would seem to be true:
when cruel birth debases, we forget.
When cruel death debases,
we believe it erases all the rest
that precedes.

But stand brave, life-liver,
bleeding out your days
in the river of time.
Stand brave:
time moves both ways,

in the nullifying, defeating, negating, repeating
joy of life;
the nullifying, defeating, negating, repeating
joy of life.

The moment of your greatest joy sustains:
not axe nor hammer,
tumor, tremor,
can take it away, and it remains.
It remains.

And it pains me to say, I was wrong.
Love is not a symptom of time.
Time is just a symptom of love

(and of the nullifying, defeating, negating, repeating
joy of life;
the nullifying, defeating, negating, repeating
joy of life).

Hardly seen, hardly felt-
deep down where your fight is waiting,
down 'till the light in your eyes is fading:

joy of life.
Where I know that you can yield, when it comes down to it;
bow like the field when the wind combs through it:
joy of life.
And every little gust that chances through
will dance in the dust of me and you,
with joy-of-life.
And in our perfect secret-keeping:
One ear of corn,
in silent, reaping
joy of life.

Joy! Again, around-a pause, a sound-a song:
a way a lone a last a loved a long.
A cave, a grave, a day: arise, ascend.
(Areion, Rharian, go free and graze. Amen.)

A shore, a tide, unmoored-a sight, abroad:
A dawn, unmarked, undone, undarked (a god).
No time. No flock. No chime, no clock. No end.
White star, white ship-Nightjar, transmit: transcend!

White star, white ship-Nightjar, transmit: transcend!
White star, white ship-Nightjar, transmit: transcend!
White star, white ship-Nightjar, transmit: trans

Unreleased - 1 - Make Hay

So long

So long

So long

So long

So long

My old friend died that way:

The accumulation of time

And the passing of days

Though she dug in her heels

Drug her wheels in the clay-

She dotted her eyes;

Crossed the teasels in her leaning dray

Where buzzards make circles

(And tillers make hay):

A dozen in kettle, committee & wake;

Where wind made the dust,

And sin made the snake,

And Mama made us.

But what did I make?

And how was I to know,

Down in our old goldmine

Where you were the king of the radio

And I was the keeper of Hi-Fi,

And I was the queen of the rodeo

(And everybody'd know),

And you were the keeper of the lions;

And we were gored, and abased,

And adored, and erased,

All before our time?

It was before our time.

So how was I to know?

How was I to know,

While the tune hums,

And the hand strikes the gong,

And all of us plough our row,

And the notes run
Out of measure and out of time and landing wrong?

Well the day is long,
But not so long.

My old friend died alone,
Save for the friends
And family she had known
Surrounding her bed,
None of whom in that room
Could with certainty have said,
"I've dotted my eyes
Crossed the teasels in my leaning sled,
Where buzzards make circles,
And tillers make hay:
In windrow and bale,
With tedder and rake;
Where Adam made ribs
And cattle make steak."
(And the rattling nib writes,
"What did I make?")

And how was I to know
Seeing my seconds pass in a line
If there was a way to reckon love
Except as a symptom of time?

And honey, it stretched out below us,
Humming every note
From the lowest to the highest,
but even at the highest,
We were bored, and amazed,
In accord, in a daze,
All before our time.
It was before our time.

So how was I to know?
How was I to know?
How was I to know?
How was I to know?
While the day slows,
And the sun stares, stalling,

Into the dimming barrel of night,
Where the stars are falling?
I've got no say,
But still,
I'm calling for my old friend.

We sow and we reap, again.

Unreleased - 2 - Bombs Are Whistling

I face it with my flayed skull in a glacial morning wind
it burns like salt, it's not your fault that i ain't got no skin
Crying out into the dawn until my voice is gone, I call
I love you through it all.
They said I couldn't hold you when I tried to take your hand
alarm bells rang, the nurse was saying things I can't understand
too warm, too warm I drew my arm away against the glass
is he okay? my flayed skull asked

I prayed the fear would pass
they say you need me here now
and I need that... but i'm needed

my eyes scan everyplace
and I stand guard all night
in vigil, in wardening and in waste
unheeded
wilds(?) too cold and blue
but look at those curls
how do you do?

though I cannot imagine you
recall it, or conceived
long ago and far away I know what I believe
I know, I know, I know
because they tell me that it's true
the spell will break and wake me anew
so I sit and rock and drop through space and kiss your face and sing
the smoke is thick, my skin is sick
the bombs are whistling
the death, the doom the leaden looming dread is always near
but I love you and you are here

I feared that it had won(?)
I feared that you would never find me
my darling sun/son
but you found me
and though it took awhile
now I look and find your blinding starlight smile
surrounds me

we bleed through
clear and true
here, with you now

I wish that I could show you what I know about this pain
I'll tell ya now, I don't know how, but I'll be back again
for bowed within the scouring wind that lays low everything
'I love you,' my flayed skull sings

Unreleased - 3 - Marie at the Mill

I see you coming down in your cherry wool coat
bare to the throat like Marie at the Mill
Where might you go from your lowly amour
Where they hoard you like gold in the hills

Sink from my side to the cold riverbed
Mary you go ahead; I will follow in time
the work keeps me here with a few pioneers
magnetizing a permanent line
save for the coat, there was nothing to bring
it was found you could sing
you were sent to the bay
at seminary, you passed and were buried
I rose there the very next day

for if you weren't born at the right time my dear
just keep trying and trying and trying again
as for the end it is not what you fear
you're just slippin' a glove from your hand

like this
down, down, down, down
your wrist
down, down
the list of lives
husbands and wives
dozens of times
around again and then

out of all of the girls, heard my coloratura and called me the heir of Melba(?) & myth
I cross the Atlantic
from Boston to Nantes
On the hand of my dear Mr. Smith

Then came his talk(?) of perdition and sin
like a cold winter wind come to blow me away
I was impatient and sought education
on stage and the Champs-Élysées
I left on my own with the clothes on my back
and my own name intact

and my own bills to pay
I left him in debt
with his feather ___ 'alouette, je te plumerai'
I had the honor to sing Mendelssohn
on the Ternary lawn
for the brave and the fool/few(?)
but it was my joy
to be called to Bayreuth
For who toiled a slave comes anew a prince

For gentler worthiness and merit won
who ruled a king may wander in rags for things
Done and undone and done and undone

I wed Mr. Russak, a fan(?)
and producer of amateur music
all lambent(?) in pearls
Held court in Newport
amused myself before I threw off the veil of the world
and when in time he sank under the sea
what he deeded to me was enough to begin
as secretary and past emissary
I rose through the ranks from within

my carnelian snuff bottle carved as a peach
and a small sterling wagon
well that was part of the set
consigned to the waters of Elliott beach
left behind with your Pall Mall Gazette

and it was not luck
put me there by his side
when the old colonel died
and the adepts appeared
and oh, what they shared
well you had to be there
but i'll tell you if you wanna hear:

"Henry your work here is done
Annie will carry it on.
Marie, write it all down,
til the keynote is found."
you run it up and down

and round and round and round and

so I think as I could
all the gaps as a pill were for good(?)
and only good
through some lapse in a life long forgot
I'd won the right to clean the room and transcribe the thoughts
of the boy from the beach with his pervious soul
poor little teacher got you doing as you're told
and even so
there is danger here in the sun
Honey, tell me what has Sirius done?
I hear it all but I cannot assume
none may I follow to the octagon room
the boy from the beach beckoned and called
Lord, he'll leave (and unhand it all)?

I see the clock on the wall
I hear the knock on the door but that is all

and when my work here is through
Henry, will you find me anew
little stranger
my old friend
woo me and win me
again and again and again
all over again
all over again
all over again

(then she sing/talks this last part)
(this is rough so stay with me)

there's a lodger in me
larger than me
saw the cross in the garden where your process came to be and
cut you free
though your father tried to reunite
with you, and Nitya was allowed to die
despite the lies we are grist in the mill

On the list I'm Helios still, Sun-Wielder,
Brünnhilde's running,

She is,
Running around, and round x6

Unreleased - 4 - Little Hand

Take her downtown,
the time has come
At last I can hear her song
Water contracts-I, cold, hold fast
like the last of the iron lungs
My child and me,
through the miles and leagues,
fall as hard and sessile as hail(?)
Echoing laughter,
'fore and after,
oh, the raft of the the violet snail

Now doesn't that sight put the fear of God in you?
Green light sweeps like a night stick swinging?

Sonar softly pinging

I am appeased by what I have seen
Now turn around ma, you already saw
what you may and can look no further
Haunted the post where the holy ghost pulls us down through the rayless water

Holding a child
now ain't it nice,
ain't it wild
and sweet?
On the verge of anguish
ain't it absurd?
I do not have words,
it is not for a lack of language

Tethered to our floating home,
we scout for your crown and it's playground

your periscope, your parapet careening(?)

Our God and king,
thy father watches the sheep
And I swear on my soul if it is all folderol,
let us ring round the roses, honey

Garbling all our sounds of woe
into hey nonny nonny nonny

Last and at least,
when the fire has ceased,
And a failsafe-essential-
break away
Shot is released,
we rise automatically
folderol, not to die, to die today

Music sets us spinning and spinning,
inscribed the memory of the honey bee
With the silence of the ballerina

We took a little walk
across the lawn,
It was two o'clock
with my soft shoes on
I met you at the dock,
may I cross the calm(?), I called
"May I tag along?"
Hear you bawl
a little sad song
It's a sad song,
keep singing it, honey, it ain't long
Sing and I'll keep you safe and warm
until the dawn

DSRV-2 Avalon
Wherever you are,
wherever you've gone
Leanin' your cheek in to the apple yellow dawn
at highway one
We've been itchin' to meet you,
recommission and meet you
If you listen I'll teach you
a sad song

Sing your machinery to sleep
and shut the door
Even Janthina once was as you are;
Sworn anathema to the guns and the megatons and all

Only Janthina can defeat the men of war

If you could only hear my joy
just to know her,
tie her little shoe,
take her little hand and say "hello" to her
hello
And there really ain't a lot I can show her

Up on the deck
are we safe from harm?
Are we ready to surface?
In every respect:
sound the alarm
Oh, we'll fall so fast,
it will feel slow
We will arrive before you know
We're free to go if we don't get stuck,
we'll be there by morning with a little luck

Lay her down, Tom(?)
we are overrun
But there is time for another story
Smoke at the door, a(?) siphonophore,
coiling blue as a morning glory

It is the hour,
see the little hand
See the lambs we have kept and guarded
Tower of steel
cartwheeling in the sand,
with the force of the waters parted

It is the hour
we are far from home
We, the lambs who will not be slaughtered
I am not afraid,
I am not alone
I'm not alone,
I have brought my daughter

I'm not alone

Unreleased - 5 - The Air Again

June of '78
Who are you? So arrayed
On the banks of the Lake Adair
Pale lacuna agape
And like the moon in the lake
You are not there
My poor canary

At uncertain behest Maggie blown to the west
In a shimmering dust of gold
With her pale yellow hair they would call her 'canary'
And I loved my Maggie so
And that is all you need to know

Women here, ain't ever glad- not even Emma Nevada!
Coming back to share her wedding cake-
Women here ain't ever free (and Emma never left!) we never leave;
We'd never last, we never asked, we never stake a claim, or complain or take

Not til I made a play for a parcel that lay
On the Amador county line
Had the notion that I'd find employ by-and-by
At the Lonesome Willow Mine
But they don't enlist my kind

In the meantime
Set to prospecting where I was able
and laying my Maggie a table
And when it was warm we would pan
When it stormed, play Vingt-et-Un
And when it was cold they'd come sniffin' with gold in their hands

On and on and again
On and on and again
You do what you can

Take an eighth of an ounce in allowance for my tax, only a dance
If alone and abandoned and cast aside you know the pastor tried in vain to ask her hand
Even he- eh, everybody did

And I had a plan but they had to sign away my mine
And the deed left us free to scrape and bleed and go to seed and never marry
Not canary, canary, canary, canary, canary, canary, canary, canary, canary

In the spring of that year when the tinker was here
Gals would hire him to mend their tin
I heard 'em swarm from afar like a storm in a jar
Like a choir of cherubim
Singing him, hymn, hymns

Whispering Maggie had gone (must've skipped with someone)
Sounded wrong though it did seem fair
April turned into May and I looked every day for you Maggie
Til I heard they found a whore with the golden hair
On the shores of the Lake Adair

On the slough she was spread, loose and languid and
Dead from the kindness that she had shown
Still she told me her tale lifting veil after veil
To expose a grin of bone
My yellow rose in the ___ blow

And though I long to believe as I muddied my sleeve
And I studied the Wiccan hap(?)
And I want to revive she was never alive but by the grace and the whim and the will and the y
And the wickedness of men

But what to do then?
I hauled myself up from the shore and
I called at the door of the foreman
I told him and he laughed

So alas there was savagery there:
Left a hole in his heart you could roll
A cabbage in. A cabbage?! Oh no, no, just a little one Maggie, just a little one

On and on and again
Til they saw what I am
And I am never done, I am never done

Went inside for the light
got a paper and a pen
Where to begin?

You sue for the rights, route for the strike
through the alluvium to where it heeds(?)
For putting ___ to the end of ___ the deed(?)
A noose on a live oak tree bent over the saloon tent and
Meant for me and Maggie

Although it wasn't him
it could've have been him
or anyone who had done
What I know so many men
intended when they came or went
so arrogant arrogant arrogant arrogant arrogant arrogant arrogant arrogant

Held a cloth to my hands
Taking stock of my plans
Well, there was something I had to make right
I took his old buggy whip
And I lowered his skip
In the glow of the sodium lights
With a load of dynamite

Maggie said, "I am here"
And with a touch on the ear(?)
"After thirty years down in the mines
Help me lead out the mules
Help me free the poor fools
Let them see for the very first time
They were blind, blind, blind"

Then we rode for the _____ and we beckoned, ooh, reflectin'
And she opened her neck like a stream
I saw the Father appear, heard her sob in my ear
Like a mob of cherubim
Howling, "him, him"
It was him
It was him!

So I threw a charge down the shaft
In a cart with the pastor
Who spat and evangelized
He was the last and the worst
Canary always goes first

To sing where the waters rise
(Hear her sing, go on now, Maggie)

On and on, on and on, on and on and again
And on and on
On and on and again
On and on and again
Then a knock and they fall in
knock and they all fall in
And down and in, and down and in

We pass away
But we pass it on like a baton down in the mine
And so they return
Pull the pumps, fill the sumps --- something they will never learn
They will never learn
And even if the churn drill and the stamp mill and the Pelton wheel
And the smoking furnace all a'burning, overturning, earning
She will never breathe the air
Again air again air again air again air again air again air again air

Like the screech of a flare
Or like they're reaching for air
Beneath the smoldering eiderdown
Veins of gold, still outstretched
In a silent arrest
For miles and miles around
And if I'm underground...

Let me join in that line
Let me toil in that mine
Let me find what is hiding there
Let me dig where I durst
Let me drink when I thirst
Let me breathe the peril air
And breathe for my canary
And breathe
Let me breathe
Let me breathe for my canary
Breathe for my (whispered: canary canary canary)
Breathe for my
Canary always falls first

Breathe for my (whispered: canary canary canary canary)
(repeated 2x)

Unreleased - 6 - No Wonder

Take it with me, love
To a place it can be loved
Little bird, little stone, shine
In light of the undying
Dig with your hands, dear
Gather our friends dear
And I will cover in dust, dear
Silence and trust dear.
Stay through the winter
Wait for the splinter,
And the green in the springtime
Queen and her king time

Sweetness all summer and fall
Hit like a tremor
And split in the autumn
Pit with no bottom.

And after the fall, out in the country
In the long drought with you, honey
And I call(?), daughter and son
Ours to adore whatever may come
After our chores end, and our money
And our scores are settled and done
Darling I will stay til the last
Plates are all filled, trays are all passed
Ain't it a thrill, ain't it a gas?
Forded(?) the hill, and don't it go fast?
At the foot of the hill, we empty our glasses

And I'll follow you over,
Will you follow me under?
Crawl through the shadows,
Call out the wonder.
Oh how I'll love you,
Time will tell-
I'll never tire of you.
I'm just tired of myself, dear.

And as our days, waft in a ream

All patters(?) away, soft as a dream
We laugh and we race
Off and on, we
Capture a stray pod on a breeze
Hammer a stake, mark in our seed
Manage to rake, water, and weed
Hundred to one our garden will grow
But wonder or none, I wanna be known
Wanna be stung, wanna be shown
Want for no one but you and your
Warm openin' arms
Watching the rolling storm clouds sail by

our window and darken the valley
Pale, pocked, and dimpled
Crocodile bellies
We wait all night and count the thunder
There is no lightning
It is no wonder.

But just before dawn, water comes streaming
In the dark, every bead
Burns like a star, blinking to sleep
Burns like a spark, burrowing deep
Under the lawn, quiet and green
Rain has begun, honey come see
Under the sun, rising like steam
Wonder or none, I wanna be seen
Wanna be-eventually, eventually

Grow through the winter, and summer
Surely and slowly
Little stone, shine of wonder
At home with you only

Unreleased - 7 - Home Economics

With our heads full of gray
by the end of the day,
won't you pour me a Mapleine tonic?
Lower the shades
on the terms of the trade
And the glare of the barreling comet

my mind is easy.
My mind is easy,
Me and my queasy stomach.

Now here come my failures
assailing me merrily,
caroling stereophonic,
and it's breaking your heart to see
how far they've got to me.
That's the cornerstone
of ordinary home economics.

We've got doctors, and plumbers,
and camps for the summer
to cancel, reschedule, and promise.
I answer the phone,
and make plans, and postpone,
and atone for all of my wrongness and

my mind is easy.
My mind is easy,
though bees besiege my bonnet.

The worry and guilt
and my heels hurry me
up the hill 'til I keel at the summit.
And this hunger and scarcity,
it just doesn't seem fair to me,
with all the rest of them
not invested in these home economics.

But I would not be far from you,
I wish not to part from you

and I love you. I want just to show it.
It's worth any verse
that I may never write,
though it hurts tonight to know it,
but my mind is easy.
My mind is easy
You're everything that I wanted.

Your laugh and the things that you
say and your soft little
weight in my lap like a rabbit.
And I'll do anything for you,
but just what do you think I do?
Cue the gramophone!
Leave your momma in the home economics.

If you reckon it's stifling,
being a housewife in the
guise of your glowing electronics,
you should know there's no version
of (h)ours that incurred,
nor life that we were promised,

but my mind is easy.
My mind is easy.
I'm only one in a long list

who birth and who nurse
and who serve and return
to the earth with no purchase upon it.
And I cannot tell you no lies.
Children, you cannot sell or buy
what cannot be owned.
That's the property of home economics.

And I can't pay my loans
without trading in these home economics!

Unreleased - 8 - Rovenshere

Soft cheek upon the sill,
soft light of morning
We await your arrival
See to your survival
See it spread below you there,
the settlement/sediment of Rovenshere.
Wild strawberries grow
among the herds of buffalo-
enough to go around and around.
Our love is in the very ground
and suspended in the air
o'er the land of Rovenshere.

There is something I wanna show you.
There is something bothering me.
Will you walk me home, honey?
There is something I want you to see.

Some other gravid pelagical magic pulls
at the gulls, flashing, rolls of the wings/underwings. We/they wheel away
in flockly steadiness, exodus to the east in Vs offset,
making glyphs, snaking like the hissing edge of a wave

There's an ocean over there, honey.
I believe they're going to that sea.
Smell it in the air, honey.
Do you wanna find it with me?

Depot agent, switch man, track man, dispatcher, bridge tender, rodman, hustler, waiter, plat

Lately I've been listening-
Tell you this, I know where they're going
Rolling in the distance
I hear the pistons and whistle a'blowing

Overhead the smudge heavily rises,
scud spreads and disguises with grease and coal

The flockly steadiness like
tossed confetti drifts

across the continents
Evidence of the geese and the gulls

I mean to be of service to you,
Chaperone a lonesome frontier (?)
How do you do?
I'll welcome you to the border, my dear.

Porter, pointsman, boilerman, gandy dancer, flagman, brakeman, yardmaster, steward, signal m

I plan to be there at the station,
Once you're safely boarded, my dear, it's a
Separate conversation
You go on and I will stay here
By my side, the love of mine stands
Golden spike in his hands hammering time into place

I see your faces against the glass
Angels and acrobats are dancing at the gates-

All aboard! All aboard that train!
All aboard! All aboard that train!
All aboard! All aboard that train!
All aboard the train.

Lay the beds and lower the blinds,
bear my heart into the night
Ain't it heavy? Ain't it light?
What we carry for our time is yours and mine,
And we are gone in the blink of an eye.
The shore, it shines at the end of the line.

All aboard! All aboard that train!
All aboard! All aboard that train!
All aboard! All aboard that train!
All aboard the train.

I believe you'll be alright,
At the depot, we hold tight
Where you scale the mountainside
And prevail. We abide.

And we will wait, we will ride!

But who will raise the hue and cry
for what was taken in the night:

Aching bones and failing sight
went sailing by in the blink of an eye
The rails, the ties, and the vacant sky,
"Arise and awaken!" cries the brakeman.

Soft cheek upon the sill,
brakes squeak high and shrill-
wake you up in wonderment.
See the change you underwent.

Disembark and listen well
to the boardwalk and the carousel,
In the cool green avenues
where they're playing horseshoes

Hear the unaccountable (uncanny?)
Crowd of birds surmount the shore,
landing with a caterwaul
At the end of all their tour/toil(?)

It is theirs and yours my dear,
farewell to the engineer
Wish I could see you there
in the land of Rovenshere.

[Spoken word:]
Well I hope you listen very carefully children,
because there's not a star in the sky you can follow to get there.
There's no means of navigation.
You have to convene at the station, and get a ticket, be patient.
Seems strange, but it's not so different that you can't find your way there,
or breathe the air, or that you don't want to stay there.
And though you may by mistake be waylaid,
find a seat on the great machine, full steam, 42 tons, and Lord!
Hear it run through the buffalo grass,
huffing like lungs along the tracks that shine in the sun
like a line of honey slowly poured, shining like a silken cord,
wandering through the hills and wood of Rovenshere at last,
where the waves crash on the shore
and bask in the light of the Lord(?), way-down in the wide/white(?) gorge,

where the tide roars and the white gulls arrive,
soar and dive, score the sky like lowering knives,
performing the rites of Rovenshere at last.
In the past, I was there. It was allowed of me.
And so that you may know just a little bit about me, I'll tell you:
I have seen the white clouds fleeing their own shadows to the sea, scattering beams.
I have gathered sweet apples cast from the trees,
and cherries, plums, tangerines; heard the trunks creak in the breeze,
heard the drunk bees knocking petals from the lemon trees,
and the meadow-peas, and the nettle and anemones.
And all lock arms, laugh and spill pell-mell down the hill to-
well, you know where.
But I took the stairs.
And in the village square we'd hear the ringing of the dinner bell
and all would know that all is well,
announcing with a gallant sound all are accounted for and found.
For you see, no calamity befalls your friends or family at all in Rovenshere.
Well, that's the hope. That's the prayer.
It's not utopia, it's not heaven- though it may as well be-
It's just a time and a place that I'll never see,
but don't you worry about me!
With my feet up on my rock candy chimney and my gingerbread pied-à-terre,
up there on the coastline in a home of my own Ma and Pa's design.
Do you see? I do for you what they did for me.
And you can do for yours in due course.
And if it's just a story- that don't make it any less true.
Oh well, if it's a song does that make it any less true?
Well, I suggest you tell that to the company and crew of the Rovenshere Express
and then go collect your personal effects,
head on back West.
Or you could stay, and I hope you do.
And that's how you get there anyway-

Choo choo!